



**Institute for
National Security Strategy**

STUDYING CHINESE SECURITY POLICY: TOWARD AN ANALYTIC FRAMEWORK

Author(s): JING-DONG YUAN

Source: *The Journal of East Asian Affairs*, Vol. 13, No. 1 (Spring/Summer 1999), pp. 131-195

Published by: [Institute for National Security Strategy](#)

Stable URL: <http://www.jstor.org/stable/23257218>

Accessed: 25/06/2014 05:39

Your use of the JSTOR archive indicates your acceptance of the Terms & Conditions of Use, available at
<http://www.jstor.org/page/info/about/policies/terms.jsp>

JSTOR is a not-for-profit service that helps scholars, researchers, and students discover, use, and build upon a wide range of content in a trusted digital archive. We use information technology and tools to increase productivity and facilitate new forms of scholarship. For more information about JSTOR, please contact support@jstor.org.



Institute for National Security Strategy is collaborating with JSTOR to digitize, preserve and extend access to
The Journal of East Asian Affairs.

<http://www.jstor.org>

STUDYING CHINESE SECURITY POLICY: TOWARD AN ANALYTIC FRAMEWORK

JING-DONG YUAN

I. Introduction

The rise of China and the implications for international and regional security in the coming decades have been the focus of attention among policy makers, the media, and analysts alike over the past few years. At the heart of the current debates are the critical questions of whether a rising China will, and to what extent, pose a serious challenge or even a threat to international and regional stability, and how such a challenge is to be dealt with. Three schools of analyses, based on different perspectives and premises, have dominated the debates and compete for the attention of policy makers. The "China threat" school predicts that a rising China, with rapid economic growth, an increasing military buildup, revived irredentist demands, and a residual authoritarian domestic political system, will be increasingly assertive and confrontational, and in due course will challenge the status quo and upset global/regional balances of power.¹ The best strategy would be to contain or constrain China before it becomes too powerful and therefore too costly to do so.² The optimists, on the other hand, while fully aware of China's inevitable ascendance, suggest that China is not likely to challenge the international system even if it becomes stronger

¹ See, for example, Richard Bernstein and Ross H. Munro, *The Coming Conflict with China* (New York: Knopf, 1997).

² Gideon Rachman, "Containing China," *The Washington Quarterly* 19:1 (Winter 1996), pp.129-140; Gerald Segal, "East Asia and the 'Constraint' of China," *International Security* 20:4 (Spring 1996), pp.107-135.

given its history, culture, and Confucian orthodoxy and that its growing interdependence with members of the international community and participation in international organizations may encourage more accommodative and cooperative behaviors from Beijing. Indeed, a strong case can be made that if anything, a policy of accommodation and incorporation toward China will likely integrate this rising power into the international system thus avoiding the instability that usually comes with the rise of great powers.³

The cautious pragmatists, as the third school of analysts may be called, focus on capabilities, the regional balance of power as well as intentions. They suggest that notwithstanding the phenomenal growth and increases in both economic and military power in the past two decades, China's power projection capabilities remain limited and the country still faces enormous internal problems and external constraints.⁴ Given the gap between aspirations and capabilities, China's policy toward its neighbors must be conservative; cautious probing rather than an outright conflictual posture would be the most likely behavior.⁵ The best strategy to influence Chinese

³ William Overholt, *The Rise of China* (New York: Norton, 1993); Bruce Comings, "The World Shakes China," *The National Interest* 43 (Spring 1996), pp.28-41; Fei-Ling Wang, "To Incorporate China: A New Policy for a New Era," *The Washington Quarterly* 21:1 (Winter 1998), pp.67-81.

⁴ Andrew J. Nathan and Robert S. Ross, *The Great Wall and the Empty Fortress: China's Search for Security* (New York: Norton, 1997); Joseph S. Nye, "China's Re-emergence and the Future of the Asia-Pacific," *Survival* 39:4 (Winter 1997-98), pp.65-79; Samuel S. Kim, "China as a Great Power," *Current History* (September 1997), pp.246-251; Paul H.B. Godwin, "Uncertainty, Insecurity, and China's Military Power," *ibid.*, pp.252-257; Avery Goldstein, "Great Expectations: Interpreting China's Arrival," *International Security* 22:3 (Winter 1997/98), pp.36-73.

⁵ See, for example, Robert S. Ross, "Beijing as a Conservative Power," *Foreign Affairs* 76:2 (March/April 1997); *idem*, "Why Our Hardliners Are Wrong," *The National Interest* 49 (Fall 1997), pp.42-51; Michael G. Gallagher, "China's Illusory Threat to the South China Sea," *International Security* 19:1 (Summer 1994), pp.169-194; Karl W. Eikenberry, "China's Challenge to Asia-Pacific Regional Stability," in Richard J. Ellings and Sheldon W. Simon, eds., *Southeast Asian Security in the New Millennium* (Armonk: M.E. Sharpe for the National Bureau of Asian Research, 1996),

policy then is to accommodate China's interests but try to condition its behaviors through the manipulation of payoff matrices for Beijing's decision makers.⁶

The key issue in the debates is the nature and direction of China's post-Cold War security policy. Writing in the early 1980s, one student of Chinese foreign policy pointed out that the field traditionally had "suffered from theoretical impoverishment" and required more vigorous systematic and critical analyses.⁷ One can suggest that the same defect remains evident in the post-Cold War study of Chinese security policy. Analyses remain ad hoc and are rarely, if ever, structured in conceptual and methodological frameworks. This essay seeks to address these problems. Two motivations drive this study. One is the concern with developing a more systematic approach to the study of Chinese security policy, taking note of the developments in Security Studies since the end of the Cold War. The second relates to policy. If the rise of China is beyond question, then our understanding of how a powerful China will operate in the international system and the regional context will be particularly pertinent, given the perception that China will increasingly be a destabilizing force and threat to global and regional peace and stability. Related to this is the hope that a better diagnosis of Chinese security policy in terms of its sources and factors driving its behavior will in turn point to useful strategies to tackle the China phenomenon.

pp.89-122; Eikenberry, "Does China Threaten Asia-Pacific Regional Stability?" *Parameters* XXV:1 (Spring 1995), pp.82-103.

⁶ James Shinn, ed., *Weaving the Net: Conditional Engagement with China* (New York: Council on Foreign Relations Press, 1996); Gerald Segal, "'Enlightening' China?" in David S.G. Goodman and Gerald Segal, eds., *China Rising* (London: Routledge, 1997), pp.172-191; idem, "Tying China into the International System," *Survival* 37:2 (Summer 1995), pp.60-73.

⁷ Friedrich W. Wu, "Explanatory Approaches to Chinese Foreign Policy: A Critique of the Western Literature," *Studies in Comparative Communism* XIII:1 (Spring 1980), p.42.

It is important to state up front what this essay is not going to do. It will not discuss *Chinese* perspectives, debates, and commentaries on the post-Cold War international environment and how it affects China's security concerns. Nor will it discuss at any length Chinese security policy itself and some of the related issues. These are substantive and distinct topics that I believe warrant separate treatment. The next section summarizes and critiques the four distinct yet related explanatory approaches to the study of post-Cold War Chinese security policy. This is followed by a discussion of the recent debates in Security Studies and their relevance to our analysis of Chinese security policy. I will then try to develop an analytic framework and identify key variables, both at the international and domestic levels, which may influence the debates, formulation, and implementation of China's security policy and therefore should be regarded as primary candidate independent variables in our analysis. A final section recapitulates the major arguments developed in the essay and suggests areas of future research.

II. Explanations of Chinese Security Policy

While few seem to query the rise of China in the international arena, how to anticipate and interpret its implications is far from being resolved. The difficulties in fully grasping the nature and substance of Chinese security posture after the Cold War, one would suggest, are all the more revealing given the importance of the issue. It has been suggested that such difficulties stem from both the lack of access to Beijing's decision-making processes and diverse interpretations of data at hand which present ambiguous pictures. For instance,

The "external constraints/interdependence"

school says that integration has begun and is probably irreversible; the “cultural explanations” school says that integration will be slow and difficult, especially if pursued in an insensitive and heavy-handed way; and the “strategic” analysts look at actual capabilities as the best indicator of the degree to which China will be willing to adhere to international norms.⁸

Indeed, a cottage industry in interpreting Chinese security policy has developed over the past decade. A full spectrum of the literature is impossible; nor will it serve our purpose here, which is to identify some of the major *Western* explanatory approaches to the study of Chinese security policy. Therefore, I will select and then analyze a manageable segment of this literature dating from the late 1980s, which I believe is representative of the current state of the field. The selection criteria are as follows: I will include (1) authors who have long worked on Chinese security policy issues; (2) articles in recognized key security-focused and China/area-oriented journals that deal explicitly with Chinese security policy issues; and (3) books/monographs or chapters that concentrate on Chinese security policy. Four typologies or general approaches are then identified/classified based on the collected sample works.

The Rising Power Thesis

The rise of China has been measured by several indicators. First and foremost is the phenomenal economic growth averaging over nine percent that has been sustained over the past two decades, tripling China’s gross national product

⁸ David B.H. Denoon and Wendy Frieman, “China’s Security Strategy: The View from Beijing, ASEAN, and Washington,” *Asian Survey* XXXVI:4 (April 1996), p.438.

(GNP) during that period.⁹ Using the purchasing power parity (PPP) indicator, the International Monetary Fund (IMF) already puts China as the third largest economy in the world and poised to overtake Japan and even the United States in the next twenty years.¹⁰ A second indicator has been China's military buildup over the past decade. With double-digit increases in defense expenditure, imports of advanced Russian weaponry to enhance power project capabilities, and the restructuring of the People's Liberation Army (PLA) into an integrated, leaner, and more mobile fighting force, China is seen as presenting a credible and serious challenge to the regional balance of power.¹¹ A third indicator is more behavioral than material, which is the perceived (and occasionally demonstrated) Chinese assertiveness in handling international affairs and growing irredentism. China's rise encourages it to pursue great-power ambitions in Asia Pacific. It has sought to become a blue water maritime power by boosting its power projection capabilities and by extending and establishing naval presence in both Southeast Asia and South Asia to the Indian Ocean.¹²

That rising China will pose a challenge to or even upset the international system and regional balance of power is based on a number of premises. The first is that great powers will act like great powers. Rising powers will likely challenge the status quo and demand changes in the rules of the game because

⁹ Dwight Perkins, "How China's Economic Transformation Shapes Its Future," in Ezra Vogel, ed., *China-US Relations in the Twentieth Century* (New York: American Assembly, 1997), chap. 4; cited in Nye, "China's Re-emergence," p.67.

¹⁰ Overholt, *The Rise of China*, p.54.

¹¹ David Shambaugh, "Growing Strong: China's Challenge to Asian Security," *Survival* 36:2 (Summer 1994), pp.43-59.

¹² Larry M. Wortzel, "China Pursues Traditional Great-Power Status," *Orbis* 38:2 (Spring 1994), pp.157-175.

[c]hallengers [to the existing international system] are those powerful and dissatisfied great nations who have grown in power after the imposition of the existing international order. Their elites face circumstances where the main benefits of the international order have already been allocated. The conditions for conflict are present. Peace is threatened when challengers seek to establish a new place for themselves in the international order, a place to which they believe their increasing power entitles them.¹³

China, as a dissatisfied but rising power, so goes this line of argument, will also seek to expand its sphere of influence through political, economic, and military means until the marginal costs become equal or exceed potential marginal benefits.¹⁴ China has been compared to Japan and Germany in the 1930s, a non-status quo power increasingly nationalistic, seeking not only to right the wrongs of the past so to speak, which includes unification with Taiwan, recovery of territories of the South China Sea, and reclaiming Hong Kong and Macau, but also claiming a predominant voice in deciding regional international relations. No amount of economic interdependence or multilateralism is going to constrain Chinese behavior.¹⁵

¹³ Jacek Kugler and A.E.K. Organski, "The Power Transition: A Retrospective and Prospective Evaluation," in Manus I. Midlarsky, ed., *Handbook of War Studies* (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 1989), p.174;

¹⁴ June Teufel Dreyer, "Regional Security Issues," *Journal of International Affairs* 49:2 (Winter 1996), pp.391-411. The classic argument, of course, remains Robert Gilpin, *War and Change in World Politics* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1981). See also, Paul Kennedy, *The Rise and Fall of the Great Powers* (New York: Vintage, 1987); and A.F.K. Organski and Jacek Kugler, *The War Ledger* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1980).

¹⁵ Gerald Segal, "The Giant Wakes: The Chinese Challenge to East Asia," *Harvard International Review* 18:2 (Spring 1996), pp.26-27, 71-72.

And there have been historical precedents and there is no reason to believe that China will be an exception. Indeed, if anything, China, because of its acute sense of past humiliation and victimization (see below), has even more reasons to have its "rightful place" in the community of nations. David Shambaugh argues: "What is worrying about China's rise is historical precedent. Both history and scholarship clearly suggest that nations in economic transition tend to be assertive externally, and that accommodating a rising power into the established order has proved difficult and disruptive."¹⁶ For instance, a recent study comparing Wilhelmine Germany and post-1978 China concludes that the two share many similarities: co-existence of rapid development of market economies with continued domination of non-capitalist states; the role of the military in maintaining authoritarian rule; and nationalism as an ideology and expression of victimization at the hands of foreign powers.¹⁷ Links are therefore alluded, with reference to historical precedence, between rapid internal economic growth and external expansion. If history holds, this argument runs, then China presumably will set off on an expansionist path as well.¹⁸

A second premise derives from the lateral pressure argument. A presumed reason as to why China would most likely pursue an expansionist policy is the classic lateral pressure thesis. According to Choucri and North, population growth, technological change, and resource demands interact with each other and create lateral pressures. As a growing population and industrialization absorb an ever-greater amount of

¹⁶ David Shambaugh, "Containment or Engagement of China? Calculating Beijing's Responses," *International Security* 21:2 (Fall 1996), p.185. For an opposite view, see Wang, "To Incorporate China."

¹⁷ John W. Garver, *Will China Be Another Germany?* (Carlisle Barracks, PA: U.S. Army War College, March 29, 1996).

¹⁸ Aaron L. Friedberg, "Ripe for Rivalry: Prospects for Peace in a Multipolar Asia," *International Security* 18:3 (Winter 1993/94), p.16.

resources and energies, rising demands may sooner or later exhaust domestic deposits and internal ability to procure the necessary food stocks, energies, and raw materials for industrialization. This will exert pressure on the state to look beyond its border to obtain these resources. One sure way to secure stable supplies of these will be to establish a sphere of influence and, better still, control over territories believed to be endowed with the necessary deposits. This can then lead to interstate rivalry, competition, and conflict. What follows may be alliances, arms races, and so on, touching off crises, escalation, and eventually leading to war.¹⁹ The fact that China has lately turned from an oil exporter to importer and consequently a heightened sense of sea as territories and the claims over the Spratly Islands are the more revealing signs of what can be expected of an energy-hungry China.²⁰

Yet another argument is that with the end of the Cold War and the drawdown of both Soviet and US military presence in Asia Pacific, the regional balance of power is in flux and, no longer fettered by the superpower overlay and competition, historical animosities and rivalries reassert themselves. Coupled with this uncertainty is the lack of institutions in the region. This gives China the opportunity to establish regional hegemony and influence.²¹ Whether or not a power vacuum

¹⁹ Nazli Choucri and Robert C. North, *Nations in Conflict: National Growth and International Violence* (San Francisco: W.H. Freeman, 1975); Choucri and North, "Lateral Pressure in International Relations: Concept and Theory," in Midlarsky, *Handbook of War Studies*, pp.289-326.

²⁰ Martin Walker, "China and the New Era of Resource Scarcity," *World Policy Journal* 13:1 (Spring 1996), pp.8-14; Kent E. Calder, "Asia's Empty Tank," *Foreign Affairs* 75:2 (March/April 1996); Nayan Chanda, "Treacherous Shoals," *Far Eastern Economic Review*, 13 August 1992, pp.14-16; Mark J. Valencia, "Energy and Insecurity in Asia," *Survival* 39:3 (Autumn 1997), pp.85-106; idem, *China and the South China Sea Dispute*, Adelphi Paper No. 298 (London: IISS/Oxford University Press, 1995); Michael Leifer, "Chinese Economic Reform and Security Policy: The South China Sea Connection," *Survival* 37:2 (Summer 1995), pp.44-59.

²¹ Barry Buzan and Gerald Segal, "Rethinking East Asian Security," *Survival* 36:2 (Summer 1994), pp.3-21.

exists in Asia Pacific is debatable;²² however, some analysts see Chinese behavior, in particular the recent military buildup, as not a reaction to the insecurity and uncertainty engendered by the end of the Cold War in both the global and regional contexts, but rather a move by authorities in Beijing to seize the opportunities to enhance national power and prestige, hence boosting China's standing and status in the international arena.²³

A rising China thus poses a long-term security threat to the Asia-Pacific region because of the greater resources that can be devoted to the military buildup, a tract record of the propensity for the use of force, and the fact that deterrence and the use of economic sanctions may prove inadequate in stopping China from asserting itself and imposing its preference on its neighbors. The liberal argument that prosperity leads to peace will not work in China's case.²⁴ However, China is actually weaker than it appears and can therefore be constrained in its behavior. The question is that East Asia, which is directly affected by the growing Chinese power and its assertive policy, lacks the will to increase the marginal costs for Beijing's adventurous policy.²⁵

National Interests/Strategic Goals

A second strand of explanation is that China's security

²² Denny Roy, "Assessing the Asia-Pacific 'Power Vacuum'," *Survival* 37:3 (Autumn 1995), pp.45-60.

²³ Alastair Ian Johnston, "Realism versus Realpolitik: Explaining Chinese Security Policy in the Post Cold War Period," paper presented at the ISA-JAIR Joint Convention on "Globalism, Regionalism and Nationalism: Asia in Search of its Role in the 21st Century," 20-22 September 1996, Makuhari, Japan. On the prestige issue, see also, Sheng Lijun, "China's Foreign Policy Under Status Discrepancy, Status Enhancement," *Contemporary Southeast Asia* 17:2 (September 1995), pp.101-125.

²⁴ Denny Roy, "Hegemon on the Horizon? China's Threat to East Asian Security," *International Security* 19:1 (Summer 1994), pp.149-168.

²⁵ Segal, "East Asia and the 'Constrainment' of China."

policy to a large extent is a reaction to developments in the international arena. "China may do well by the high church of realpolitik in the post-cold war world. Its analysts certainly think more like traditional balance-of-power theorists than do most contemporary Western leaders and policy analysts."²⁶ While this line of argument shares with the rising power thesis, i.e., a fundamental realist worldview of anarchy and self-help, it also differs from the former in that it is more passive and reactive, with maintaining security as the ultimate objective, rather than pursuing goals driven by the thirst for power.

The genesis of China's post-Cold War security policy actually dates back to the early 1980s when the premise of that policy had been based on the presumption that there would be relative but balanced decline of both superpowers, against which China could build up its own capabilities and therefore play a more prominent role in a multipolar international system. However, events did not develop as Beijing had anticipated. The US-allied victory in the Gulf War, the collapse of the Soviet Union, and the isolation in the aftermath of Tiananmen have left Beijing's leadership to wrestle with continuing a foreign policy that focuses on maintaining an amicable environment for China's economic development and managing conflicts with its neighbors; but at the same time pursue military buildup in response to its own relative decline vis-à-vis the US and in the international arena.²⁷ Indeed, China faces several severe challenges to its security with the end of the Cold War even as it now enjoys a most malleable security environment as a direction invasion has all but disappeared. One is the reduced flexibility, and hence the influence (or the

²⁶ Thomas J. Christensen, "Chinese Realpolitik," *Foreign Affairs* 75:5 (September/October 1996), p.37.

²⁷ Paul H.B. Godwin, "China's Security Policy Enters the 21st Century: The View From Beijing," in Dianne L. Smith, ed., *Asian Security to the Year 2000* (Carlisle, PA: Strategic Studies Institute, U.S. Army War College, December 15, 1996), pp.37-64.

perception of it) in global politics framed in the Cold War context.²⁸ In addition, instead of the much anticipated emergence of multipolarity in world politics, what has developed apparently is a “unipolar moment” whereby the US, although declining, seems to have managed to run the UN and dictate the terms of many important issues in the global and regional arenas.²⁹ Furthermore, while the disintegration of the Soviet Union removed a visible physical threat, Beijing is aware of the potential destabilizing impact the newly established Central Asian republics could bring to bear on China’s northwestern region. Of particular concern is the rise of Islamic fundamentalism and its appeal to separatist elements in that part of China, which incidentally also is home to many of the country’s nuclear testing and launching sites.³⁰

The insecurity of Chinese security after the Cold War thus can be understood from two different angles. One is a redefinition of China’s security interests and strategic frontier. While in the past national survival was the predominant concern and hence security policy hinged largely on preparing for “an early, major, and nuclear war,” in particular a land invasion from the Soviet Union, such a scenario no longer forms the basis of Chinese security calculation. Instead,

²⁸ Samuel Kim argues that China had enjoyed a global power status within the Cold War framework of the strategic triangle “without first having acquired the reach or the requisite normative and the material resources of a global power.” “China’s Pacific Policy: Reconciling the Irreconcilable,” *International Journal* 50:3 (Summer 1995), p.466.

²⁹ Paul H.B. Godwin, “China’s Asian Policy in the 1990s: Adjusting to the Post-Cold War Environment,” in Sheldon W. Simon, ed., *East Asian Security in the Post-Cold War Era* (Armonk: M.E. Sharpe, 1993), pp.118-147; idem, “Force and Diplomacy: Chinese Security Policy in the Post-Cold War Era,” in Samuel S. Kim, ed., *China and the World: Chinese Foreign Relations in the Post-Cold War Era* (Boulder: Westview Press, 1994), pp.171-186..

³⁰ Gerald Segal, “China and the Disintegration of the Soviet Union,” *Asian Survey* XXXII:9 (September 1992), pp.848-868; J. Richard Walsh, “China and the New Geopolitics of Central Asia,” *Asian Survey* XXXIII:3 (March 1993), pp.272-284; Shambaugh, “China’s security policy in the post-Cold War era,” pp.96-97.

Beijing's interests have extended to maritime territories and hence protecting these against intrusion and even their recovery now become top policy priorities. In this context, Beijing feels uncertain and vulnerable in an environment of limited, high-tech conflicts, as fully demonstrated by the Gulf War. There has also been a spatial shift in China's security policy, which is now seen as increasingly focusing on the Asia-Pacific region, where it faces the challenge of managing actual and potential conflicts with its neighbors, and the uncertainties surrounding Japan, India, Russia, and the Korean peninsula. And there is also the more imminent issue of national unification concerning Taiwan. A second angle from which to assess its (in) security situation concerns the future role of the United States in the region. Ultimately, what role the US is to play in particular features prominently in Beijing's calculations. China's security policy, military modernization being a key element, can be understood as such. In other words, military buildup has not reacted to the presence or absence of direct military threats but rather tailored to new interests and new missions, as well as a path to building China into a power of regional predominance and global status.³¹

China's sense of both confidence and insecurity must also be seen in the light of the *realpolitik* theme of its strategic culture (see below). This dialectic understanding of international politics, coupled with a keen sense of balance of power politics, continues to guide the making of its security policy. Indeed, as an ancient Chinese axiom goes: "The nation that has no enemy in mind will perish." Notwithstanding the disintegration of the Soviet Union in 1991 and the fact that China's security environment for the first time since 1949 has been marked by the absence of any serious threat, Chinese decisionmakers have not come around to viewing

³¹ David Shambaugh, "The Insecurity of Security: The PLA's Evolving Doctrine and Threat Perception Towards 2000," *Journal of Northeast Asian Studies* 13:1 (Spring 1994), pp.3-25.

the world as conflict-free. While the Soviet threat is receding, new challenges to China's security interests are emerging and have to be dealt with.

In other words, the nature of international relations remain conflictual and threats ubiquitous. The sources of threats have therefore become multifarious and hardly clear-cut. Potential and actual contenders for territorial claims can be, and indeed are, economic partners or human rights allies. The strategies of the adversaries are no longer just military in nature; they can be economic, cultural, and packaged in the forms of engagement, enlargement, as well as containment and constraint. Under such circumstances, the creating of enemies and exposure of their insidious nature serve both the purposes of preparing for coming confrontation (though to some extent this must still be the case) and maintaining domestic social and political cohesion.³²

Balance of power consideration therefore features prominently in Beijing's strategic calculation. Developments in China's major contenders for regional influence are of particular significance. Japan and India prove to be potential rivals in the medium to long term. Japan certainly has the wherewithal to become a serious military power given its economic and technological prowess.³³ There remain unresolved, even if currently shelved, territorial disputes between China and India, with the latter also providing refuge to the Dalai Lama and the separatist Tibetans. Both also view each other as rivals fighting for regional influence.³⁴ While

³² See, for example, Matt Forney, "Patriotic Game," *Far Eastern Economic Review*, 3 October 1996, pp.22-28.

³³ David Shambaugh, "China and Japan towards the Twenty-First Century: Rivals for Pre-eminence or Complex Interdependence?" in Christopher Howe, ed., *China and Japan: History, Trends, and Prospects* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1996), pp.83-97.

³⁴ J. Mohan Malik, "China-India Relations in the Post-Soviet Era: The Continuing Rivalry," *The China Quarterly* 142 (June 1995), pp.317-353; John W. Garver, "Sino-Indian Rapprochement and the Sino-Pakistan Entente," *Political Science Quarterly* 111:2 (Summer 1996), pp.323-347.

China and Russia are currently on good terms, the Beijing-Moscow entente can hardly be seen as firmly based on long-term geo-strategic foundation.³⁵ Developments on the Korean peninsula are also crucial to China's security, especially given the nature of the North Korean regime and the many domestic difficulties Pyongyang faces that Beijing fears could entice adventurous behavior from the North.³⁶ In this regard, Beijing might for now acquiesce in the continued deployment of US forces in South Korea and the still useful role of the ROK-US alliance in deterring North Korea, any future development, in that a unified Korea remains an ally of the United States, could pose a serious security problem for Beijing.³⁷

Hence for Beijing, given the so many uncertainties, the best way to handle a range of potential security threats in the post-Cold War era is to build a powerful, modern economy as the foundation of China's comprehensive national strength. This may be Beijing's foremost security objective in years to come. Military buildup, meanwhile, serves a number of purposes: It boosts national prestige; provides means for coercive diplomacy; counters the rise of Japanese and Indian military power; deters potential challengers to its interests; and readies

³⁵ Jennifer Anderson, *The Limits of Sino-Russian Strategic Partnership*, Adelphi Paper 315 (London: Oxford University Press for IISS, December 1997); Majan Menon, "The Strategic Convergence Between Russia and China," *Survival* 39:2 (Summer 1997), pp.101-125.

³⁶ Banning Garrett and Bonnie Glaser, "Looking Across the Yalu: Chinese Assessments of North Korea," *Asian Survey* XXXV:6 (June 1995), pp.528-545; Weixin Hu, "Beijing's Defense Strategy and the Korean Peninsula," *Journal of Northeast Asian Studies* XIV:3 (Fall 1995), pp.50-67.

³⁷ Fei-Ling Wang, *Tacit Acceptance and Watchful Eyes: Beijing's Views about the U.S.-ROK Alliance* (Carlisle, PA: Strategic Studies Institute, U.S. Army War College, January 24, 1997); idem, "Changing Views: Chinese Perceptions of the United States-South Korea Alliance," *Problems of Post-Communism* 43:4 (July/August 1996), pp.16-25.

for use to protect these interests.³⁸

In sum, the national interest/strategic goal argument suggests that China's security policy is not so much aggressive or expansionist as it is opportunistic in that it seeks to maintain the image of a responsible power while at the same time maximize power and profit under the existing structure of constraints. Its approaches to both the arms control and regional security cooperation issues reflect this characterization.³⁹ China has to find its niche in the new international order where existing security structure, largely constructed during the Cold War, remains intact and constrains China's pursuit of great power status. The responses to these constraints contradict public statements of good intent and the consequent ambiguity surrounding its true intentions leaves the Asia-Pacific region feeling suspicious about Beijing's ambition to dominate the region.⁴⁰

Historical Legacy and Nationalism

Many analysts point to the historical baggage as an important element informing Chinese security policy.⁴¹ China has been depicted as dissatisfied with the status quo and determined to right the wrongs of its humiliated past. This has engendered fear of its neighboring countries of Beijing's

³⁸ Bonnie S. Glaser, "China's Security Perceptions: Interests and Ambitions," *Asian Survey* XXXIII:3 (March 1993), pp.252-271.

³⁹ Roxane D. V. Sismanidis, "China and the Post-Soviet Security Structure," *Asian Affairs: An American Review* 21:1 (Spring 1994), pp.39-58.

⁴⁰ Roxane D. V. Sismanidis, "Chinese Security as Asia Evolves: Constraints and Ambiguities," *Journal of Northeast Asian Studies* 15:2 (Summer 1996), pp.63-80.

⁴¹ David Shambaugh, "Growing Strong: China's Challenge to Asian Security," *Survival* 36:2 (Summer 1994), pp.43-59; Samuel S. Kim, *China's Quest for Security in the Post-Cold War World* (Carlisle Barracks, PA: U.S. Army War College, July 29, 1996); Lowell Dittmer and Samuel Kim, eds., *China's Quest for National Identity* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1993).

expansionist intents.⁴² There are essentially two themes. One is that there is a strong need for asserting national sovereignty and independence because China's past weakness had subjected the country to humiliation and invasion. Samuel Kim observes:

The historical experience of Western and Japanese imperialism during the century of national humiliation, far from being forgotten, seems to have endowed the Chinese with the nineteenth-century conception of absolute state sovereignty and taught the lesson of the importance of power politics in international relations and its corollary -- that China could not be respected without power.⁴³

There are at least three elements to this theme. One is that weak and fragmented China invites foreign invasion and subjection. The "one hundred years of humiliation" since the Opium War of 1840 has been a constant reminder. The second is a particularly suspicious view of multilateralism, given China's own unhappy experiences in the past (e.g., League of Nations' handling of Japanese invasion of China in 1931). Drawn on these two elements is the third, that is, whatever the international environment, which the Chinese never see as constant but always in flux, the surest way of preserving national sovereignty is to develop a strong state while striving for the unity of the nation. There is hence a strong emphasis on the linkage between domestic (regime)

⁴² Buzan and Segal, "Rethinking East Asian Security," pp. 6-7.

⁴³ Samuel S. Kim, "China and the World in Theory and Practice," in Kim, ed., *China and the World: Chinese Foreign Relations in the Post-Cold War Era* (Boulder: Westview Press, 1994), pp. 13-14.

security and external security.⁴⁴ A corollary to this is the determination to maintain absolute sovereignty and maximum maneuverability. For this reason, alliance or tight alignment should be avoided. And this furthers China's argument that its modest defense modernization is all the more necessary since China is not allied to any other major powers and hence has to draw on its own resources to protect itself.⁴⁵

The second theme derives from the Sino-centric world order, which assumes an implicit Chinese hegemony in East Asia. It has been thus alleged that the post-Cold War Chinese security policy is part and parcel of a concerted effort to restore the glory of the past. Contrary to most of the official Chinese statements, a strong future China will likely follow a course of exerting power and influence in the region. Its history (century of shame and irredentism), a view of internal-external threats integrated, and self-perceived moral highground will encourage China to pursue regional hegemony to suit its interest. China will remain unsatisfied until and when this has been fulfilled. There is a strong sense of "victimization" regarding territorial issues and Taiwan. China would be wary of threats to its security rather than vice versa. This "mostly historically-based Chinese under-sensitivity to the security fears of others, especially the Japanese, reduces the effect of what otherwise might act as a powerful inhibition to seeking hegemony."⁴⁶

Allen White has suggested that an insecure post-Deng leadership may resort to nationalism to boost their own standing and legitimacy. He cites three types of nationalism:

⁴⁴ Jianwei Wang, "Coping With China as a Rising Power," in James Shinn, ed., *Weaving the New: Conditional Engagement with China* (New York: Council on Foreign Relations Press, 1996), pp.133-174, esp. pp.147-153.

⁴⁵ Shambaugh, "Growing Strong," pp.46-47.

⁴⁶ Denny Roy, "The Foreign Policy of Great-Power China," *Contemporary Southeast Asia* 19:2 (September 1997), pp.121-135.

affirmative, assertive and aggressive. "Affirmative nationalism centres exclusively on 'us' as a positive in-group referent with pride in attributes and achievements. Assertive nationalism adds 'them' as a negative out-group referent that challenges the in-group's interests and possibly its identity. Aggressive nationalism identifies a specific foreign enemy as a serious threat that requires action to defend vital interests."⁴⁷ Alastair Johnston echoes this third type by describing Chinese identity realism as the regime's efforts to intensify in-group cohesiveness and the potential dangers posed by out-groups.⁴⁸ Factional struggle within the party leadership, perceived or real external threat, or simply mass mobilization all serve to elevate nationalism as an increasingly important factor in foreign and security policy.⁴⁹ The recent popularization of the "sea as motherland" and the pride of the nation in defending its own territorial waters can be attributed to the use of nationalism in foreign policy. And some assert that the biggest threat that China can pose is when it reacts to what it perceives to be the slight to its sovereignty and over-reacts, leading to erratic behavior. "The danger is that China's aspirations for greatness will overreach its actual powers."⁵⁰

Domestic Politics/Ascendancy of the PLA

The fourth explanation for a more assertive Chinese security policy is domestic politics. Two important elements can be

⁴⁷ Allen S. Whiting, "Chinese Nationalism and Foreign Policy After Deng," *The China Quarterly* 142 (June 1995), pp.295-316; quote at p.295.

⁴⁸ Johnston, "Realism versus Realpolitik."

⁴⁹ For a recent analysis of how Mao used the 1958 Quemoy (Jinmen) crisis to mobilize support for his domestic policy, see Thomas J. Christensen, *Useful Adversaries: Grand Strategy, Domestic Mobilization, and Sino-American Conflict, 1947-1958* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1996), chap. 6.

⁵⁰ Lucian W. Pye, "China: Not Your Typical Superpower," *Problems of Post-Communism* 43:4 (July/August 1996), pp.3-15.

identified. One is that the nature of China's political system makes it likely to resort to force to settle disputes. This derives from the democratic peace argument in that it is suggested that democracies do not fight one another while they may go to war with non-democracies.⁵¹ There is also the argument that the dynamics of domestic politics can lead to external adventures. This is particularly the case with earlier studies of Chinese security, where a significant body of the literature focuses on the domestic politics and its impact on Beijing's policy toward the United States and the Soviet Union.⁵² This has several underlining motivations. One is to divert attention to domestic political crisis. This stratagem has been alluded to China's war with India in 1962 and with the Soviet Union in 1969. Another is driven by the need to outmaneuver domestic opponents through mass mobilization; the bombing of Quemoy (Jinmen) in 1958 has been cited as a case in point.⁵³ Yet a third is the argument that the transition from authoritarian rule to democracy is highly unstable and therefore conducive to aggressive behavior.⁵⁴

Of course, in China's case, most attention has been focused on the alleged increasing role of the military. This in turn relates to the pivotal role the PLA is to play, and indeed may

⁵¹ See, for example, Michael W. Doyle, "Kant, Liberal Legacies, and Foreign Affairs: Part 1," *Philosophy and Public Affairs* 12 (1983), pp.205-235, and "Kant, Liberal Legacies, and Foreign Affairs: Part 2," *ibid.* pp.323-353; Michael E. Brown, Sean M. Lynn-Jones, and Steven E. Miller, eds., *Debating the Democratic Peace* (Cambridge, Mass.: The MIT Press, 1996).

⁵² Robert S. Ross and Paul H.B. Godwin, "New Directions in Chinese Security Studies," in David L. Shambaugh, ed., *American Studies of Contemporary China* (Armonk: M.E. Sharpe with the Woodrow Wilson International Center for Scholars, 1993), pp.139-144.

⁵³ Christensen, *Useful Adversaries*, chap. 6; Jack S. Levy, "The Diversionary Theory of War: A Critique," in Midlarsky, *Handbook of War Studies*, pp.259-288.

⁵⁴ See, for example, Kugler and Organski, "The Power Transition," pp.171-194; Edward D. Mansfield and Jack Snyder, "Democratization and the Danger of War," *International Security* 20:1 (Summer 1995), pp.5-38.

have already played, in the leadership transition, in particular in the post-Deng power lineup.⁵⁵ While the People's Liberation Army has by and large retreated from the kind of engagement in domestic political processes from the height of the Cultural Revolution⁵⁶ and indeed reforms of the last two decades have deliberately endeavored to make the separation of the state management one of the top priorities of the Party leadership, the post-Deng transition and potential jockeying for the top leadership position and therefore currying favor with the military, has again elevated the PLA to a covetous position.

The military are playing a more active role driven by the fact that the various factions within the current generation of Chinese leadership need the support of the military. The recent increases in defense spending must be seen in the light of both the military's growing influence and the civilian leadership need to accommodate the former's demands. This is not to say that we are likely to see a phenomenon of "gun commanding the party" but more accurately a new version of Party-Army symbiosis in which the PLA and the Party leaderships interact and "logroll" to advance each other's specific institutional/personal interests.⁵⁷

Another important factor is that if one considers the emerging regionalism within China and the weakening center-local hierarchy, and the potential ethnic separatist

⁵⁵ David Shambaugh, "China's Military in Transition: Politics, Professionalism, Procurement and Power Projection," *The China Quarterly* 146 (June 1996), pp.265-298; Ellis Joffe, "Party-Army Relations in China: Retrospect and Prospect," *The China Quarterly* 146 (June 1996), pp.299-314; and Joffe, "Ruling China After Deng," *Journal of East Asian Affairs* 11:1 (Winter/Spring 1997), pp.183-220.

⁵⁶ See, for example, Nan Li, "Political-Military Changes in China, 1978-89," *Security Studies* 4:2 (Winter 1994/95), pp.426-458.

⁵⁷ Ellis Joffe, "Party-Army Relations in China: Retrospect and Prospect," *The China Quarterly* 146 (June 1996), pp.299-314; and "How much does the PLA make foreign policy?" in David S.G. Goodman and Gerald Segal, eds., *China Rising: Nationalism and Interdependence* (London and New York: Routledge, 1997), pp.53-70.

movements,⁵⁸ the importance of the PLA as the ultimate guarantor of the Chinese state has risen, as has its greater role in the country's foreign and security policy making.⁵⁹ It is therefore expected that China's military will wield increasing influence in the security policymaking process as the champion of nationalism, unity, and also motivated by institutional interests: the emphasis on threats and the adoption of a hard-line posture justify greater defense expenditure. However, a more reasonable explanation of the PLA's interests in security policymaking is that they are the ones that will ultimately answer the call to implement the leadership's foreign and security policy objectives, including the protection and assertion over territories and sovereignty and they hardly want to get caught in a situation where their capabilities cannot ensure the success of the mission assigned.⁶⁰

The PLA's concern with the modern condition of warfare may therefore be a major reason why it wants to have a greater voice in China's security policy making. Indeed, the Gulf War has prompted debates among top military brass over how to reconcile political/diplomatic objectives and military/strategic efficiency.⁶¹ There has been clear advocacy within the military to take preemptive strikes in future limited

⁵⁸ Two recent treatises along this line are, David S.G. Goodman and Gerald Segal, eds., *China Deconstructs: Politics, Trade and Regionalism* (London and New York: Routledge, 1994); and Gerald Segal, *China Changes Shape: Regionalism and Foreign Policy*, Adelphi Paper No. 287 (London: International Institute for Strategic Studies, 1994).

⁵⁹ Michael D. Swaine, *The Military and Political Succession in China* (Santa Monica, Calif.: RAND, 1992); idem, *The Role of the Chinese Military in National Security Policymaking* (Santa Monica, Calif.: RAND, 1996).

⁶⁰ Joffe, "How much does the PLA make foreign policy?"

⁶¹ Hwang Byong-moo, "Changing Military Doctrines of the PRC: The Interaction Between the People's War and Technology," *The Journal of East Asian Affairs* XI:1 (Winter/Spring 1997), pp.221-266; Harlan W. Jencks, "Chinese Evaluations of 'Desert Storm': Implications for PRC Security," *Journal of East Asian Affairs* (1992). See also, Michael Pillsbury, ed., *Chinese Views of Future Warfare* (Washington, DC: National Defense University Press, 1997).

high tech war. In other words, while the political/diplomatic objectives are protecting the nation's territorial integrity and basically non-aggressive, the ways to achieve these must follow military logic and "objective laws" and can therefore assume an offensive and preemptive character. The use of force is not only necessary; it is imperative so that political goals are met.

Assessments

The four approaches discussed above offer different interpretations of the implications of China's rise to great power status and explain why Beijing's security policy will likely pose a challenge to international and regional stability. However, there are serious flaws in the analyses. To begin with, China's growing economy and military has largely been depicted in lineal, absolute terms and rarely put into proper historical and comparative perspective. While it is undeniable that the past two decades of reforms has resulted in phenomenal economic takeoff and a sustained high annual growth rate, one must recognize that pre-reform Chinese economy was at a very low starting base and, indeed, according to the post-Mao leadership, was nearing the abyss of collapse. Adding to that is the fact that in overall terms, China's economic growth has been largely driven by the inflow of foreign direct investment and technology transfers, exports of low-end, labor-intensive processing goods, and the mushrooming of small- and medium-sized local enterprises producing consumer goods meeting a rising domestic demands. China remains deficient in key industries and lags behind in science and technology. And it is facing increasing energy shortages, infrastructural bottlenecks, and the difficulties in restructuring the money-losing state-owned enterprises. In this regard, past performance cannot guarantee that a double-

digit growth can be sustained.

The lack of a comparative perspective in the analyses is all the more puzzling, given the fact that most analysts must be self-described realists whose discussion of power and capabilities one would expect to be firmly anchored in relative as well as absolute terms. In this regard, China's rise, in particular its military buildup, should be analyzed in the context of not only in comparison with its own past records, but also more importantly, with its actual and potential contenders over time.⁶² Seen in this light, China's defense modernization may have its most significant debut in ridding the doctrine of the People's War, restructuring the military organization, and having developed some "pockets of excellence."⁶³ These would mostly be in the realm of lineal comparison and, again, note must be taken that China's military buildup started from a very low base. More sanguine analyses readily identify limitation in power projection and the still relatively low defense expenditure, areas of deficiencies in Chinese defense industrial and technological bases, organizational impediments, external export controls, training, and the erosion of military professionalism ironically as a result of reforms.⁶⁴ In global and regional military-balance terms,

⁶² See Goldstein, "Great Expectations."

⁶³ Nan Li, "The PLA's Evolving Warfighting Doctrine, Strategy and Tactics, 1985-95: A Chinese Perspective," *The China Quarterly* 146 (June 1996), pp.443-463; Paul H.B. Godwin, "From Continent to Periphery: PLA Doctrine, Strategy and Capabilities Towards 2000," *The China Quarterly* 146 (June 1996), pp.464-487; Chong-Pin Lin, "China's military modernization: perceptions, progress, prospects," *Security Studies* 3:4 (Summer 1994), pp.718-753.

⁶⁴ David Shambaugh, "China's Military: Real or Paper Tiger?" *The Washington Quarterly* 19:1 (Spring 1996), pp.19-36; Paul H.B. Godwin, "Force Projection and China's National Military Strategy," in C. Dennison Lane, Mark Weisenbloom, and Dimon Liu, eds., *Chinese Military Modernization* (New York: Kegan Paul International, 1996), pp.69-99; Chong-Pin Lin, "The Power Projection Capabilities of the People's Liberation Army," in *ibid.*, pp.100-124; Dennis Blasko, "Better Late Than Never: Non-Equipment Aspects of PLA Ground Force Modernization," in *ibid.*, pp.125-143; Shaoguang Wang, "Estimating China's Defence Expenditure: Some

China's recent progress in defense modernization has neither given it any decided advantage in the latter context nor has it significantly closed the gap in the former. While China is developing, others have not stood still. If anything, China's gains are more than offset by the regional military buildups.⁶⁵ What is more important is that the Chinese military has yet to fully grasp the significance of Revolution in Military Affairs (RMA) and chart its own direction accordingly.⁶⁶ This is not

Evidence from Chinese Sources," *The China Quarterly* 147 (September 1996), pp.889-911; Paul H.B. Godwin, "'PLA incorporated': estimating China's military expenditure," in Gerald Segal and Richard H. Yang, eds., *Chinese Economic Reform: The Impact on Security* (London and New York: Routledge, 1996), pp.53-77; Chong-Pin Lin, "The Extramilitary Roles of the People's Liberation Army in Modernization: Limits of Professionalism," *Security Studies* 1:4 (Summer 1992), pp.659-689; Ellis Joffe, "The PLA and the Chinese Economy: The Effect of Involvement," *Survival* 37:2 (Summer 1995), pp.24-43; Eric Arnett, "Military technology: the case of China," in *SIPRI Yearbook 1995: Armaments, Disarmament and International Security* (Oxford: Oxford University Press for SIPRI, 1995), pp.359-386; Bates Gill, "The Impact of Economic Reform upon Chinese Defense Production," in Lane, Weisenbloom, and Liu, *Chinese Military Modernization*, pp.144-167; and John Frankenstein and Bates Gill, "Current and Future Challenges Facing Chinese Defence Industries," *The China Quarterly* 146 (June 1996), pp.394-427.

⁶⁵ Nye, "China's Re-emergence"; Goldstein, "Great Expectations"; Richard A. Bitzinger and Bates Gill, *Gearing Up for High-Tech Warfare? Chinese and Taiwanese Defense Modernization and Implications for Military Confrontation Across the Taiwan Strait*. CAPS Papers No.11 (Taipei: Chinese Council of Advanced Policy Studies, September 1996).

⁶⁶ Michael J. Mazarr, *The Revolution in Military Affairs: A Framework for Defense Planning* (Carlisle Barracks, PA: U.S. Army War College, June 10, 1994); Jeffrey R. Cooper, *Another View of the Revolution in Military Affairs* (Carlisle Barracks, PA: U.S. Army War College, July 15, 1994); Earl H. Tilford Jr., *The Revolution in Military Affairs: Prospects and Cautions* (Carlisle Barracks, PA: U.S. Army War College, June 23, 1995); Steven Metz and James Kievit, *Strategy and the Revolution in Military Affairs: From Theory to Policy* (Carlisle Barracks, PA: U.S. Army War College, June 27, 1995); Joseph S. Nye, Jr., and William A. Owens, "America's Information Edge," *Foreign Affairs* 75:2 (March/April 1996), pp.20-36; Eliot A. Cohen, "A Revolution in Warfare," *ibid.*, pp.37-54. For perspectives on China and in the Asia-Pacific regional context, see Bates Gill, *China and the Revolution in Military Affairs* (Carlisle Barracks, PA: U.S. Army War College, May 20, 1996); M. Ehsan Ahrari, "Chinese prove to be attentive students of information warfare," *Jane's Intelligence Review* 9:10 (October 1997), pp.469-473; Paul Dibb, "The Revolution in Military Affairs and Asian Security," *Survival* 39:4 (Winter 1997-98), pp.93-116.

to suggest that the Chinese military buildup does not matter; it merely directs our attention to some methodological issues that need to be taken care of to yield more balanced analyses.

A second critique of the conventional wisdom is that it fails to make a persuasive case that China is a non-status quo and indeed a revisionist power. Additionally, it also reflects an unresolved issue among realists regarding the distinction between those states, which are power maximizers, and those states whose main concerns are minimum security, that is, "whether states seek the minimum power required for security or additional power for goals other than security."⁶⁷ On these accounts, China's policy and behavior in both the international and regional arenas present only an indeterminate mixed record. China has been cited as trying to bend the rules in seeking admission to the World Trade Organization (WTO), and refusing to abide by the international nonproliferation regimes in restricting the transfers of weapons of mass destruction (WMDs) and relevant delivery systems and technologies. This has been construed as rising China determined to challenge the established norms and demand the re-writing of rules. Despite the above charges, China, since her return to the international community in 1971, has by and large embraced the norms and accepted the rules of international economic and political systems. Her participation in the international economic organizations and the overall attitudes toward international security regimes, however reluctant and belatedly, have at worst been adaptive rather than disruptive, while in certain cases, have been quite forthcoming and cooperative.⁶⁸ Taken as a whole, China's behavior since the

⁶⁷ Randall L. Schweller, "Neorealism's Status-Quo Bias: What Security Dilemma?" *Security Studies* 5:3 (Spring 1996), pp.90-121.

⁶⁸ See, for example, Harold K. Jacobson and Michel Oksenberg, *China's Participation in the IMF, the World Bank, and GATT: Toward a Global Economic Order* (Ann Arbor, Mich.: University of Michigan Press, 1990); Samuel S. Kim,

early 1970s should put it among the ranks of status quo, rather than revisionist, states.

While many analysts are right on target in making the domestic-international linkage when explaining Chinese security policy, they tend to emphasize those aspects of domestic politics that likely will lead to more aggressive external behavior. This assertion is premised on the assumption that democracies are more pacific while authoritarian states are prone to violence. The assumption itself remains highly contested in IR theory and therefore dubious as a definitive independent variable in assessing the China case.⁶⁹ In any event, China's experience demonstrates that the linkage between domestic difficulties/conflict and external adventure is at best indeterminate, as cases of past records have indicated. In other words, domestic crisis does not necessarily lead to diversion strategies, i.e., pursuing external conflictual behaviors.⁷⁰

Two related issues readily come to mind. One is the PRC's record of use of force. The other is the role of the PLA in national security policy making. The tract record of Chinese use of force points to conservatism in general although in certain cases, Beijing's resort to force has been swift and beyond the normal consideration of rationality, as evident in its

"China's International Organizational Behavior," in Thomas W. Robinson and David Shambaugh, eds., *Chinese Foreign Policy: Theory and Practice* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1994), pp.401-434; Alastair Iain Johnston, "Learning versus Adaptation," *The China Journal* 35 (January 1996), pp.27-61; Zachary S. Davis, "China's Nonproliferation and Export Control Policies: Boom or Bust for the NPT Regime?" *Asian Survey* XXXV:6 (June 1995), pp.587-603.

⁶⁹ See, for instance, Christopher Layne, "Kant or Cant: The Myth of Democratic Peace," *International Security* 19 (1994), pp.5-49; Randall L. Schweller, "Domestic Structure and Preventive War: Are Democracies More Pacific?" *World Politics* 44 (1992), pp.235-269. For a literature review, see Steve Chan, "In Search of Democratic Peace: Problems and Promise," *Mershon International Studies Review* 41:Supplement 1 (May 1997), pp.59-91.

⁷⁰ Andres D. Onate, "The Conflict Interactions of the People's Republic of China, 1950-1970," *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 18:4 (December 1974), pp.578-594.

decision to confront the United States in the Korean War.⁷¹ Analyses of several key conflicts China was involved in have suggested that Beijing's use of force seems to have been largely reactive, defensive, and limited in scope and duration. The objectives have been to teach the adversaries lessons, or give warning signals.⁷² Indeed, Chinese conflict behavior and use of force has been characterized as constituting "five distinct and sequential phases: probing, warning, demonstrating, attacking, and de-escalating," and reflecting the "coercive diplomacy" model of limited and controlled use of force to achieve specific political objectives in given situations.⁷³ Almost all crises and conflicts involve territorial issues and most if not all were initiated by other countries than China.⁷⁴ Two features are readily identifiable in Chinese conflict behavior. One is that China has been very sensitive to the issue of territorial integrity; the use of force to protect its territories remains a prominent policy option. The other is the measured manner in which force has been applied.⁷⁵

Many analysts have noted the PLA's ascendance in domestic politics and have speculated the impact of the military on

⁷¹ Ross and Godwin, "New Directions in Chinese Security Studies," pp.150-152.

⁷² Steve Chan, "Chinese Conflict Calculus and Behavior: Assessment from a Perspective of Conflict Management," *World Politics* 30:3 (April 1978), pp.391-410; Andres D. Onate, "The Conflict Interactions of the People's Republic of China, 1950-1970," *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 18:4 (December 1974), pp.578-594; Allen S. Whiting, *The Chinese Calculus of Deterrence: India and Indochina* (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 1975), and idem., "The Use of Force in Foreign Policy by the People's Republic of China," *Annals of the American Academy of Political and Social Science* 402 (July 1972), pp.55-66.

⁷³ Samuel S. Kim, "China and the World in Theory and Practice," in Kim, ed., *China and the World: Chinese Foreign Relations in the Post-Cold War Era* (Boulder: Westview Press, 1994), p.20.

⁷⁴ Jonathan Wilkenfeld, Michael Brecher, and Sheila Moser, *Crises in the Twentieth Century. vol.2: Handbook of Foreign Policy Crises* (New York, 1988), pp.160-164.

⁷⁵ Edward S. Boylan, "The Chinese Cultural Style of Warfare," *Comparative Strategy* 3:4 (1982), pp.341-364.

national security policy making.⁷⁶ While a more influential military certainly will promote its own parochial interests,⁷⁷ will China's security policy therefore be more threatening to its neighbors? In other words, is a more powerful PLA more inclined to the use of force in solving disputes? This depends not only on its own strategic culture, its confidence in the use of force as an effective tool (the 1979 incursion into Vietnam and the 1991 Gulf War would introduce some elements of caution, one may suggest), but also the likely impacts arising from these that may affect the PLA's other interests such as obtaining Western technology for defense modernization. Indeed, one can argue that the civilian leadership and particularly its more moderate, pragmatic faction, can just present such a case to the PLA. The recent restraint betrayed by Beijing toward the Diaoyutai (Senkaku) island conflicts, despite reported PLA militancy regarding the matter, indicates that broader political, diplomatic, economic considerations play no small part in the policy outcomes.⁷⁸

The above assessments indicate that a major impediment to more systematic, theoretically informed analyses may be the artificially separate approaches undertaken in Security Studies on the one hand, and in area/country studies on the other, and between theory and policy.⁷⁹ If anything, the study of things

⁷⁶ Ellis Joffe, *The Military and China's New Politics: Trends and Counter-Trends*, CAPS Papers No.19 (Taipei: Chinese Council of Advanced Policy Studies, September 1997).

⁷⁷ John Garver, "China's Push through the South China Sea: The Interaction of Bureaucratic and National Interests," *China Quarterly* 132 (December 1992), pp.999-1028.

⁷⁸ David Shambaugh, "China's commander-in-chief: Jiang Zemin and the PLA," in Lane, Weisenbaum, and Liu, *Chinese Military Modernization*, pp.209-245

⁷⁹ Kim, "China and the World in Theory and Practice"; Shambaugh, *American Studies of Contemporary China*; Wang Jisi, "International Relations Theory and the Study of Chinese Foreign Policy: A Chinese Perspective," in Robinson and Shambaugh, *Chinese Foreign Policy*, pp.481-505; James N. Rosenau, "China in a Bifurcated World: Competing Theoretical Perspectives," *ibid.*, pp.524-551; and Quansheng Zhao,

Chinese, or Sinology, has developed its unique methodologies and is based on particularistic perspectives and assumptions. Theoretical works, IR in general and Security Studies in particular where case studies are required to provide empirical evidence, it is normally the Western and, at most, the former Soviet, experiences that are included.⁸⁰ This also reflects the conspicuous gap between comparative and international politics in political science.⁸¹ In short, my critique is not that these explanatory approaches are wrong-headed as they are incomplete, as demonstrated by a missing link between the study of China's security policy/behavior and the more theoretically oriented debates in Security Studies. It is with this in mind that I now turn to a discussion of some of the recent debates in Security Studies, with a view to synthesizing and developing a more systematic analytical framework for the study of Chinese security policy.

III. Security Studies after the Cold War

The end of the Cold War has touched off heated debates in International Relations Theory in general and Security Studies in particular. There has been strong criticism about the failure of realist-dominated IR Theory in anticipating the end of the Cold War because of its over emphasis on structural and systemic variables to the negligence of domestic variables, including foreign policy learning and the "leap of faith" of

Interpreting Chinese Foreign Policy: The Micro-Macro Linkage Approach (Hong Kong: Oxford University Press, 1996).

⁸⁰ Alastair Iain Johnston's recent works have attempted to move beyond immediate policy concerns to place Chinese security policy in longer term and theoretical perspectives. See various citations contained in this essay.

⁸¹ James A. Caporaso, "Across the Great Divide: Integrating Comparative and International Politics," *International Studies Quarterly* 41:4 (December 1997), pp.563-591.

national political leaders.⁸² Underpinning these debates are questions about the continued relevance of structural realism as a theoretical guide to our understanding of international politics and renewed efforts to shift focus onto domestic sources of foreign policy and state behaviors. It also goes back to the level of analysis issue for determining which level, systemic or unit, is the more appropriate independent variable in the study of peace and war.⁸³ Analysts in the Security Studies field have also begun to introduce new themes, including the decline of military power in international relations; the need to rethink international relations and national security; and the recognition that a broader view of national security should be adopted.⁸⁴

And given the Cold War experiences, such debates at a time of transition and uncertainty have important bearings on both state strategies and the consequent amity or enmity their interactions may lead to. According to Barry Buzan: "For all of the contending approaches, security is an empowering word, setting political priorities, and justifying the use of force, the intensification of executive powers, the claim to rights of secrecy, and other extreme measures."⁸⁵

At the heart of the debates are questions of what, if any, new direction in security studies is needed given the continuity and change in the international geostrategic arena. Are changes

⁸² See, for example, Richard Ned Lebow and Thomas Risse-Kappen, eds., *International Relations Theory and the End of the Cold War* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1995).

⁸³ Ethan B. Kapstein, "Is realism dead? The domestic sources of international politics," *International Organization* 49:4 (Autumn 1995), pp.751-774; Randall L. Schweller, "Domestic Structures and Preventive War: Are Democracies More Pacific?" *World Politics* 44:2 (January 1992), pp.235-269; Fareed Zakaria, "Realism and Domestic Politics," *International Security* 17 (Summer 1992), pp.177-198.

⁸⁴ See David A. Baldwin's review article, "Security Studies and the End of the Cold War," *World Politics* 48:1 (October 1995), p.118.

⁸⁵ Barry Buzan, "Rethinking Security after the Cold War," *Cooperation and Conflict* 32:1 (March 1997), p.21.

fundamental enough to shake the foundation of Security Studies and hence call for drastically new agendas and direction, or, as the Gulf War demonstrates, the use of military force remains an important element in international politics and the problem of security, as structural realism would tell us? What changes are needed to address both policy and theoretical relevance of Security Studies?⁸⁶

Understandably, the need to broaden the agenda of security studies represents a response to the drastically changing nature of international politics, in particular the nature, the sources of threats, and the referent, value, and degree of security that are required, and means to achieve these goals. As well, an open debate also clarifies many important conceptual and policy-contingent issues. Thus the broadening of the agenda of security studies can actually help narrow the agenda of security in the policy realm as to avoid using force and violence to settle issues that touch on the "security" of states but can nevertheless be dealt with in other appropriate ways.⁸⁷

In a nutshell, these debates revolve around the issues of whether security itself remains a domain where the use of military force should continue to be the focus of inquiries. Analysts with different orientations or epistemological predilection answer these questions in different ways.⁸⁸ The so-called traditionalists maintain that this should continue to be the case. Power still matters. Indeed, they argue that efforts to venture into new directions or undertake new agendas have nothing new to offer but in the process dilute the cohesion of

⁸⁶ Neta C. Crawford, "Once and Future Security Studies," *Security Studies* 1:2 (Winter 1991), pp.283-316.

⁸⁷ Keith Krause and Michael C. Williams, "Broadening the Agenda of Security Studies: Politics and Methods," *Mershon International Studies Review* (October 1996), pp.229-254.

⁸⁸ For an overview of the debate among these different approaches, see Barry Buzan, "Rethinking Security after the Cold War," *Cooperation and Conflict* 32:1 (March 1997), pp.5-28.

the field.⁸⁹ A second group argues for an expanded security agenda to include the emerging non-traditional security issues that are seen as posing greater threats to both national and international security and that call for non-military solutions.⁹⁰ The critical security studies school has raised questions about the referents of security, whether or not states should remain the only subjects for which security is sought, or should people, citizens, communities be the referent points. It suggests that discourses, languages, and speech acts to a great extent condition what security is and what it is about, and governments sometimes avail this opportunity to claim special right to the monopoly of power.⁹¹

Traditional Approaches

In a much-cited controversial piece, Stephen M. Walt writes that “security studies may be defined as *the study of the threat, use, and control of military force*. It explores the conditions that make the use of force more likely, the ways that the use of force affects individuals, states, and societies, and the specific policies that states adopt in order to prepare for, prevent, or engage in war.”⁹² This state-centric, military force

⁸⁹ Stephen M. Walt, “The Renaissance of Security Studies,” *International Studies Quarterly* 35 (1), pp.211-239; Colin S. Gray, “New Directions for Strategic Studies? How Can Theory Help Practice?” *Security Studies* 1:4 (Summer 1992), pp.610-635; Richard K. Betts, “Should Strategic Studies Survive?” *World Politics* 50:1 (October 1997), pp.

⁹⁰ Richard Ullman, “Redefining Security,” *International Security* 8:1 (1983), pp.129-153; Michael E. Brown, Sean M. Lynn-Jones, and Steven E. Miller, eds., *Global Dangers: Changing Dimensions of International Security* (Cambridge, Mass.: The MIT Press, 1995); Jessica Mathews Tuchman, “Redefining Security,” *Foreign Affairs* 68 (1989), pp.162-177.

⁹¹ See, for example, Ronnie D. Lipschutz, ed., *On Security* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1995); Keith Krause and Michael C. Williams, ed., *Critical Security Studies* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1997).

⁹² Stephen M. Walt, “The Renaissance of Security Studies,” *International Studies Quarterly* 35 (1991), p.212.

focused definition echoes an earlier attempt to assess the state of the field, as defined by Nye and Lynn-Jones:

The field [international security studies] includes basic theoretical work on the causes of conflict and war, the dynamics and outcomes of conflict, the nature and perception of threats, and efforts to ameliorate or resolve conflicts caused by such threats. Analyses of the problems of nuclear strategy, arms control, and deterrence, of conventional deterrence and conventional strategy, of the determinants of the defense policies of states, studies of military organizations and civil-military relations, and military history are familiar parts of the field.⁹³

While noting the many new developments in the international arena that arguably also pose threats to nations' well-being, including environmental degradation, mass migration, transnational crimes, ... the traditionalists insist that "the need for peoples, nations, states or alliances to procure, deploy, engage or withdraw military forces must remain a primary purpose of the strategic analyst's inquiries," even as the broader political, economic and social contexts in which decisions for the use of military force must also be taken into greater consideration.⁹⁴

The traditional realist view of security and of the ways security studies should be organized continues to emphasize the predominance of force in an international system of

⁹³ Joseph S. Nye, Jr., and Sean M. Lynn-Jones, "International Security Studies: A Report of a Conference on the State of the Field," *International Security* 12:4 (Spring 1988), pp.6-7.

⁹⁴ John Chipman, "The future of strategic studies: beyond even grand strategy," *Survival* 34:1 (Spring 1992), pp.109-131; quote at p.129.

anarchy and self-help. Walt recognizes that

[m]ilitary power is not the only source of national security, and military threats are not the only dangers that states face (though they are usually the most serious). As a result security studies also includes what is sometimes termed “statecraft” -- arms control, diplomacy, crisis management, for example. These issues are clearly relevant to the main focus of the field, because they bear directly on the likelihood and character of war.⁹⁵

According to the traditionalists, even under the post-Cold War environment, security dilemma remains a variable in accounting inter-state competition, conflict, and war. As Robert Jervis put it some twenty years ago, a security dilemma exists when “many of the means by which a state tries to increase its security decrease the security of others.” Jervis further elaborated on the nature and magnitude of the security dilemma as measured in two variables: the defense-offense balance; and the defense-offense differentiation.⁹⁶

Thus for the traditionalists, what is needed is not so much the new agendas, however important they are in affecting the well-being of states, as it is renewed efforts to study how changes affect the way military power will be used.

The field needs work on basic questions such as the causes of war, the sources of cooperation, the formation of alliances, the implications of the nuclear revolution, the security effects of

⁹⁵ Walt, “The Renaissance of Security Studies,” p.213.

⁹⁶ Robert Jervis, “Cooperation under the Security Dilemma,” *World Politics* 30:2 (January 1978), p.169.

economic interdependence, the domestic sources of foreign policy, the consequences of offensive or defensive doctrines, and the cultural and cognitive biases of decision-makers.⁹⁷

If anything, it is to make the realist to recognize the realities of security studies rather than tinker with the very foundation and premises of the field.

Broadening the Agenda

The challenges to the traditional approach come first and foremost from those attacks on the state-centric framework in security analyses. To avoid the pitfall of reducing security to national security is to consider the broader milieu or various dimensions of modern life relevant to security.⁹⁸ Richard Ullman defines a threat to national security as

An action or sequence of events that (1) threatens drastically and over a relatively brief span of time to degrade the quality of life for the inhabitants of a state or (2) threatens significantly to narrow the range of policy choices available to the government of a state or to private non-governmental entities (persons, groups, corporations) within the state.⁹⁹

Instead of focusing on military threats to state territorial integrity and/or political survival, security has been defined as “value and/or system maintenance over time, and the absence

⁹⁷ Nye and Lynn-Jones, “International Security Studies,” p.21.

⁹⁸ Robert Latham, “Thinking about Security after the Cold War,” *International Studies Notes* 20:3 (Fall 1995), p.11.

⁹⁹ Richard Ullman, “Redefining Security,” *International Security* 8:1 (1983), p.135.

of threats to it.”¹⁰⁰ This makes it possible to seriously consider non-traditional security challenges such as economic vulnerability, environmental degradation, migration, and transnational crimes as also constituting considerable threats to both states themselves and the people and groups residing within. If these were identified as security threats, then obviously the use of military force would not be the most appropriate means of dealing with them.

It is accepted conventional wisdom that increasing economic interdependence may create situations that potentially can threaten states' security and well being. States can lose control over the autonomy in allocating values within their boundaries and expose themselves to the ups and downs of international market forces.¹⁰¹ Measures therefore must be taken to minimize the negative impacts that sensitivity and vulnerability can inflict. These may include preserving autonomy, restricting sale of certain commodities and technologies, developing niches, including new weapons systems and their integration.¹⁰²

Economic security, ironically, actually derives from the traditional school, although in a way as economic activities being securitized and elevated to the realm of high politics. That the economic welling is the fountain of military prowess is readily available even in works of a much older generation of international relations scholars.¹⁰³ In fact, one can argue

¹⁰⁰ Helga Haftendorn, “The Security Puzzle: Theory-Building and Discipline-Building in International Security,” *International Studies Quarterly* 35 (1991), p.5.

¹⁰¹ Robert Keohane and Joseph Nye, *Power and Interdependence* (Boston: Little, Brown, 1977).

¹⁰² Beverly Crawford, “Hawks, Doves, but no Owls: International Economic Interdependence and Construction of the New Security Dilemma,” in Lipschutz, ed., *On Security*, pp.149-186.

¹⁰³ Jacob Viner, “Power Versus Plenty as Objectives of Foreign Policy in the Seventeenth and Eighteenth Centuries,” *World Politics* 1:1 (October 1948), pp.1-29; Edward Mead Earle, “Adam Smith, Alexander Hamilton, Friedrich List: The Economic Foundations of Military Power,” in Peter Paret, ed., *Makers of Modern*

that Western, especially American, policies of export controls on East-West trade and technology transfers have their premises in the recognition that military power draws from economic strength.¹⁰⁴ What may be different in the security studies context more generally, is the concern over the sensitivities and vulnerabilities that can generate from trade, as well as the concern over dependence, relative declines, growing gaps, and so on.¹⁰⁵

Economic security then involves not only the ability to minimize vulnerability and sensitivity as a result of interdependence, it also entails maintaining the lead in technological fronts and possessing the capabilities to integrate commercial and military application of production and process technologies. As Beverly Crawford suggests,

Technological leadership is the basis of economic power, and economic power is the foundation of military might. Those states where commercial innovation flourishes and which provide the source of production for another's defense industrial base are those who are economically competitive and thus increasingly powerful. And their economic power is a growing source of political influence and can, under the right conditions, be adapted to bolster national military capabilities.¹⁰⁶

Strategy (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1986), pp.217-261.

¹⁰⁴ G. Adler-Karlsson, *Western Economic Warfare, 1947-1967: A Case Study in Foreign Economic Policy* (Stockholm: Almqvist & Wiksell, 1967); Michael Mastanduno, *Economic Containment: CoCom and the Politics of East-West Trade* (Ithaca and London: Cornell University Press, 1992).

¹⁰⁵ Buzan, "Rethinking Security after the Cold War," p.8.

¹⁰⁶ Crawford, "Hawks, Doves, but no Owls," p.162. This line of argument is nothing new. Some of the classics are still of relevance today. For important general discussions see Albert O. Hirschman, *National Power and the Structure of Foreign*

This leads to the whole argument of relative gains, which contends that whatever the systemic configuration, it is to states' best interests to pay attention to the issue of relative gains not for maximizing power but just so that one is not left behind with serious consequences. If this line of argument is sustainable in the international political economy literature, which deals presumably with trade and investment issues between largely democratic Western industrialized countries, then one can imagine the relevance of this issue in the security arena, with potentially much higher stakes if mistakes are committed.¹⁰⁷

As much as the agendas need to be broadened, so do need the actors in the decision-making processes, as well as the context within which both processes and actors operate according to set rules. The domestic political system has important bearing on security conception and policies. According to Buzan, "differences in internal construction have a substantial impact on how states define threats and vulnerabilities, and therefore on the whole construction of the security problematique."¹⁰⁸ Also important must be the recognition that states are rarely unitary actors and state policies are almost invariably the outcomes of domestic bargaining, compromises, and coalition building.¹⁰⁹ If this is

Trade (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1980; first published in 1945); Klaus Knorr, *Power and Wealth* (New York: Basic Books, 1973); Klaus Knorr and Frank Trager, eds., *Economic Issues and National Security* (Lawrence, Kansas: Allen Press, Inc., 1977). More recent discussions include Michael Borrus, Ken Conca, Wayne Sandholtz, Jay Stowsky, Steven Weber and John Zysman, *The Highest Stakes: Technology, Economy and Security Policy* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1992).

¹⁰⁷ Joseph M. Grieco, "Anarchy and the Limits of Cooperation: A Realist Critique of the Newest Liberal Institutionalism," *International Organization* 42 (August 1988), pp.485-507; Michael Mastanduno, "Do Relative Gains Matter? America's Response to Japanese Industrial Policy," *International Security* 16 (Summer 1991), pp.73-113.

¹⁰⁸ Barry Buzan, "Security, the State, the 'New World Order,' and Beyond," in Lipschutz, ed., *On Security*, pp.188-189.

¹⁰⁹ Graham Allison, *Essence of Decision: Explaining the Cuban Missile Crisis*

the case, then states "can tailor their own policies to try to influence the outcome of debates in the rival country and, consequently, their rival's behavior."¹¹⁰

Another issue is the relationship between psychology and security. It has been suggested that political leaders' belief systems, prior expectations, cognitive maps can be important factors influencing how decision-makers "define problems, assess stakes, propose solutions, and evaluate choices."¹¹¹ In earlier studies in crisis management, deterrence, and alliance formation, analysts already pointed out that given time pressure, and the fact that most people are satisficers rather than maximizers, they would normally eschew having to make tradeoffs, and select information and make decisions that would conform to their prior expectations.¹¹² This has important implications for our analysis here. As Alexander Wendt pointed out, structural constraints do not always generate similar responses and behavior. Agents, in other words, also have an important role to play.¹¹³

Recent discussions outside the main realist core treatment of security studies have reflected a broader notion of security. These approaches seek to address the roots of security threats

(Boston: Little, Brown, 1971).

¹¹⁰ Matthew Evangelista, "Internal and External Constraints on Grand Strategy: The Soviet Case," in Richard Rosecrance and Arthur A. Stein, eds., *The Domestic Bases of Grand Strategy* (Ithaca, N.Y.: Cornell University Press, 1993), p.170.

¹¹¹ James M. Goldgeier, "Psychology and Security," *Security Studies* 6:4 (Summer 1997), p.146.

¹¹² Literature on deterrence theory clearly demonstrates the limitation of rationality. See, for example, Richard N. Lebow, *Between Peace and War: The Nature of International Crises* (Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1981); Robert Jervis, Janice Gross Stein, and Richard Ned Lebow, eds., *Psychology and Deterrence* (Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1985); Jack L. Snyder, "Rationality at the Brink: The Role of Cognitive Processes in Failures of Deterrence," *World Politics* 30:3 (April 1978), pp.345-365; Edward Rhodes, "Nuclear Weapons and Credibility: Deterrence Theory Beyond Rationality," *Review of International Studies* 14:1 (January 1988), pp.45-62.

¹¹³ Wendt, "Agent-structure problem."

rather than focus on how to deal with them through defense, arms races and deterrence. In other words, security may be better obtained through not merely the traditional self-help, national security, policy, but by formulating international security policy that seek to tackle the root of the problem. Barry Buzan suggests:

Because the national security strategy ignores the sources of threats, it risks both an open-ended commitment to expenditure of resources and a failure to deal with the systemic security dynamics ... If an international security strategy is adopted, security policy focuses on the sources and causes of threats, the purpose being not to block or offset the threats, but to reduce or eliminate them by political action.¹¹⁴

International security strategy also allows lesser states to pursue goals that they otherwise could not do for national security purposes because of the constraints on resources. In particular, this gives the middle power the opportunity to influence the international security agenda and hence militate against the predominant presence of the superpowers.¹¹⁵ The introduction of the concepts of comprehensive, common, and cooperative security can be a case in point. Comprehensive security embraces all facets of security ranging from political, economic, to military and defines policy options in terms of domestic, bilateral, regional, and global levels. Common security develops from recognition that the avoidance of war, especially a nuclear war, is a common responsibility in a world

¹¹⁴ Buzan, *People, States, & Fear*, chap. 9.

¹¹⁵ See, for example, Andrew F. Cooper, Richard A. Higgott, and Kim Richard Nossal, *Relocating Middle Powers: Australia and Canada in a Changing World Order* (Vancouver: University of British Columbia Press, 1993).

of interdependence. The key element is to seek security with rather than against the adversary. Cooperative security emphasizes inclusiveness, open-mindedness in agenda setting, gradualism, habits of dialogue, and different tracts of venue.¹¹⁶ In addition, there has also been discussion on the possibility of cooperation under systemic constraints with the introduction of regimes.¹¹⁷

Critical Security Studies

Critical security studies challenges the core of the realist conception of security studies and security in that it calls for a reconceptualization of the referent(s) of security, relocating it from the state to individuals as citizens, human beings, to community, society, and identity, more exploration of the relationships between and among these referents, and moving beyond what has been described as a narrow focus on the use of military force and the link between strategic studies and the neo-realist framework. Instead of continuing to stick to the notion of rationality and rational self-interest, the core of neo-realism, efforts should be expended on the role of norms and values and how they affect the creation and maintenance of security relations.¹¹⁸ By refusing to accept that war and force

¹¹⁶ David Dewitt, "Common, Comprehensive, and Cooperative Security," *The Pacific Review* 7:1 (1994), pp.1-15; Geoffrey Wiseman, "Common Security in the Asia-Pacific Region," *The Pacific Review* 5:1 (1992), pp.42-59.

¹¹⁷ Robert Jervis, "Security Regimes," in Stephen D. Krasner, ed., *International Regimes* (Ithaca and London: Cornell University Press, 1983), pp.173-194; and idem., "From Balance to Concert: A Study of International Security Cooperation," in Kenneth A. Oye, ed., *Cooperation under Anarchy* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1985), pp.58-79.

¹¹⁸ Keith Krause and Michael C. Williams, "From Strategy to Security: Foundation of Critical Security Studies," in Krause and Williams, eds., *Critical Security Studies* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1997), pp.33-60; Michael C. Williams, "Neo-Realism and the future of strategy," *Review of International Studies* 19 (1993), pp.103-121.

are the core of the inquiry, critical security studies puts forth the argument that it is possible, and indeed imperative, to identify threats to referent objects, which can include but are not limited to states, and the securitization of these threats, which can range from the military to the non-military.¹¹⁹

Ole Wæver has defined security problems as “developments that threaten the sovereignty or independence of a state in a particularly rapid or dramatic fashion, and deprive it of the capacity to manage by itself.” However, the significance of the security discourse lies in the fact that

*In naming a certain development a security problem, the ‘state’ can claim a special right, one that will, in the final instance, always be defined by the state and its elite. Power holders can always try to use the instrument of securitization of an issue to gain control over it. We can regard ‘security’ as a speech act. [Consequently], a major focus of ‘security studies’ should be the processes of securitization and de-securitization: When, why and how elites label issues and developments as ‘security’ problems; when, why and how they succeed and fail in such endeavors; what attempts are made by other groups to put securitization on the agenda: and whether we can point to efforts to keep issues off the security agenda, or even to de-securitize issues that have become securitized?*¹²⁰

Rather than new security issues (and the old) in the post-

¹¹⁹ Buzan, “Rethinking Security after the Cold War,” *passim*.

¹²⁰ Ole Wæver, “Securitization and Desecuritization,” in Lipschutz, ed., *On Security*, pp. 54-55, 57-58.

Cold War era, important questions have been raised with regard to what is to be secured, what are the conditions of security, and how ideas about security develop and get into the policy debates.¹²¹ Therefore, “*defining* security, or even *redefining* it, becomes problematic when the *referent object* of security itself is ill-defined or changing.”¹²² In other words, whether or not threats matter to the extent that resources must be mobilized and special measures be taken involve not only (or even) objective assessments, but represent an intersubjective process. “It is a *choice* to phrase things in security (or desecurity) terms, not an objective feature of the issue or relationship itself.”¹²³

Critical security theorists also point out that the traditional notion of the state as the provider of security can very much be the carrier of violence against citizens within and therefore represents a potent threat to individual security.¹²⁴ Power and order by themselves cannot sustain long-lasting peace and security. Genuine security can only be achieved through emancipation, by which is meant “the freeing of people from those physical and human constraints which stop them carrying out what they would freely choose to do. Emancipation, not power or order, produces true security. Emancipation, theoretically, is security.”¹²⁵

A final point is that critical security studies are acutely aware of the pitfall of ethnocentrism. This, according to them, is an impediment to true understanding of the different conceptualization of threats and security firmly grounded in

¹²¹ Ronnie D. Lipschutz, “On Security,” in Lipschutz, ed., *On Security*, pp.1-2.

¹²² Lipschutz, “On Security,” pp.6-7.

¹²³ Buzan, “Rethinking Security after the Cold War,” p.24.

¹²⁴ Barry Buzan, *People, States, & Fear: An Agenda for International Security Studies in the Post-Cold War Era* (Boulder: Lynne Rienner, 1991).

¹²⁵ Ken Booth, “Security and emancipation,” *Review of International Studies* 17 (1991), p.319.

history, geography, and culture.¹²⁶ Hence the call for more focus on the plight and security dilemma of the Third World countries in terms of state building and state making, internal ethnic strife, away from the traditional, Cold War-conditioned preoccupation with superpower rivalry and the corollary of deterrence, arms race, and balance of terror.¹²⁷

While the recent debates in Security Studies have highlighted a number of contentious points, the best that can be said of them is just that. Indeed, there yet has to be a genuine exchange among the three approaches; so far they have managed largely to talk past one another. Analysts have also tended to mix security with Security Studies in their debates. David Baldwin contends that most of the discussions on security are actually efforts to redefine the policy agendas and priorities rather than the concept of security itself. These are two different things. Also separate are the concept of security and the conditions under which security is to be obtained. He identifies both the security problematique, which includes such questions as security for whom, for which values, how much security, from what threats, by what means, at what cost, and in what time periods; and the value of security, from the primary, to the core, and to the marginal, and how these are relative to other values.¹²⁸

The traditional approach has been criticized as narrow in scope and limited in methodology and areas of examination; it is almost exclusively concerned with American national security rather than international security issues. What are needed are a broader agenda, more interdisciplinary

¹²⁶ Ken Booth, *Strategy and Ethnocentrism* (London: Croom Helm, 1980).

¹²⁷ Several chapters in the Krause and Williams volume elaborate on this subject in greater detail. An earlier effort can be found in Brian L. Job, ed., *The Insecurity Dilemma* (Boulder: Lynne Rienner, 1992).

¹²⁸ David A. Baldwin, "The concept of security," *Review of International Studies* 23 (1997), pp.5-26.

approaches, and greater use of empirical and historical data and avoidance of ethnocentrism.¹²⁹ Criticisms of the concept of security dilemma point out its flawed logic;¹³⁰ it has been suggested that it is less the structural characteristics, such as anarchy and distribution of capabilities, but rather the motives of the revisionist states (nonsecurity expansion driven by greed) as the driving force. That is, "whether states seek the minimum power required for security or additional power for goals other than security."¹³¹

It should be noted that early security studies did not focus excessively on the use of military force but was very much more open-minded. Indeed, earlier works paid much more attention to the facts that (1) security might not be the only concern of states; (2) both military and nonmilitary statecraft could be at the disposal of national security; (3) a realization of security dilemma and hence an emphasis on prudence and caution in use of military force; and (4) the link between domestic affairs and national security.¹³²

An important point that needs to be made is that recognizing that security threats today are not exclusively military and may include human rights and democratization, the environment, economies, epidemics, crime, population growth and mass migration, and social injustice does not tell us how these issues will occupy the public debates and get translated into specific policy measures in competition with other concerns for attention and funds. In other words, a broader view of security is only useful if one also appreciates the institutional structures and policymaking processes. Priority remains a key

¹²⁹ Edward A. Kolodziej, "Renaissance in Security Studies? Caveat Lector!" *International Studies Quarterly* 36:4 (December 1992), pp.421-438.

¹³⁰ Charles L. Glaser, "The Security Dilemma Revisited," *World Politics* 50:1 (October 1997), pp.171-201.

¹³¹ Randall L. Schweller, "Neorealism's Status-Quo Bias: What Security Dilemma?" *Security Studies* 5:3 (Spring 1996), pp.90-121.

¹³² Baldwin, "Security Studies and the End of the Cold War," p.122.

element here. States just simply cannot do everything at the same time.

This leads to the key issue of “second image reversed.” There are two elements to it. One is the fact that political participation varies in different political systems. Authoritarian states will tend to have a greater chance of monopolizing the policymaking process and maintaining secrecy in policy deliberations. Democratic systems, on the other hand, will presumably have more pressure points where sectors or interests groups in civil society can relay their particular views on particular issues to their representatives in the government, who in turn must be accountable as they vote and opt for policies (Even this is debatable: it is not clear if the public is, if ever, well informed; media hype and simplification of issues into sound bites can mislead). A second issue is whether the state is susceptible or resistant to societal pressures. In other words, is the whole larger than its constituent parts?¹³³ What has not been explained sufficiently, and which remains today even in an era of increasing interdependence and the ever-growing role of non-governmental organizations (NGOs), is that states remain the key actors that procure, deploy, mobilize, and use force. What has changed, or rather, become increasingly recognized, is the fact that processes and institutions are important variables in the whole analysis, as states themselves are no longer regarded as unitary actors. But access remains important, how a threat becomes securitized and, what is more, leads to consideration of security measures, continue to the domain of state managers, be they the military, the executive, or the legislative.

Interestingly enough, if the concept of security is equated with the securitization of threats and therefore the granting to

¹³³ Stephen D. Krasner, *Defending the National Interests: Raw Materials Investment and U.S. Foreign Policy* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1978).

states additional powers and claims over the life of other, non-military spheres, then a broadening of the security agenda is antithesis to the liberal cause of de-securitization and greater emancipation. It is not that broadening the security agenda will make it incoherent but rather that such a move is quintessentially retrograde.¹³⁴

IV. Toward an Analytic Framework of Chinese Security Policy in the Post-Cold War Era

The above discussion of the recent developments in Security Studies highlights a number of theoretical issues. One is the concept of security cannot be taken for granted. It is both an ontological and epistemological issue. The value, scope, and the referent(s) of security are always determined depending on perspectives, whatever they may be. And the very process of defining security can be one of “intersubjective securitizing” as much as one of assessing realities. A second important point is that the military dimension of security is only one, and not even the most important, aspect in the security equation. Again, perspectives vary, so differ emphases on the preparation and use of force. A third point is that the process is as every bit important as the structure. And finally, the international-domestic link must be viewed as a loop rather than as lineal, interactive rather than cause-and-effect. These will serve as the road map for the discussion below.

To develop an analytical framework for studying post-Cold War Chinese security policy essentially starts with two sets of questions. One concerns those factors/variables at both international and domestic levels that most likely affect the making of Chinese security policy, variables that not only

¹³⁴ Buzan, “Rethinking Security after the Cold War,” pp.22-25; see also, “Ronnie D. Lipschutz, “Negotiating the Boundaries of Difference and Security at Millenium’s End,” in Lipschutz, ed., *On Security*, p.220.

affect the content but also the process by which such policy is made. A second set of questions relates to the issue of how Chinese security policy, if carried out, would either challenge the existing international and regional security arrangements or will likely result in reactions that taken together destabilize peace and order. Basically, the following key elements should be incorporated into the framework. First, we must establish what it is that the Chinese leadership defines as the nation's security. What is the concept of security in terms of scope, value, and referent(s)? From the minimum to the maximum, i.e., along the line of continuum moving from physical survival to crucial national interests, to political/regime stability, economic well-being and comprehensive national strength, to predominance and hegemony in the region so that no one can challenge its interests and dominant voice in regional affairs, that is, to restore its glorious past?

A next step is to determine, given the above variation of security interests/goals, what will likely be perceived as challenges and/or threats. A United States acting as the only superpower and dictating the terms of international politics? The potential rivalries with Japan, India, Russia? An unstable Korean peninsula? Taiwan independence and/or South China Sea territorial disputes? Economic/technological competition? Internal instability, ethnic unrest, and peaceful evolution? A third set of issues involves the means by which security goals are to be achieved. Number one on the list, and drawing on the realist tradition, is whether and to what extent the use of force and the preparation of military power remain both an important component of Chinese security policy and the key instrument of policy. How well is the PLA prepared? What progress and limitations to defense modernization can be identified? What past tract records tell us about the use of force and to what extent economic interdependence will affect

Chinese leaders' calculus of cost/benefits of the use of force? What are Chinese perspectives on and attitudes toward multilateralism and cooperative security, concert, and security regimes? Finally, one must also include the policymaking process and important players and assess the inter-group dynamics in pushing the policy tray.

Strategic Culture and Sources of Chinese Security Policy

Determining China's security perspectives after the Cold War may usefully begin with an assessment of how the leadership has defined security over time and under different external and internal circumstance. While it has been noted that China's security policy has changed from an over-emphasis on military threat to a more comprehensive understanding of the sources of potential and actual threats to security, one must also ask what has induced the redefinition of security as now embracing economic development, territorial integrity, unification, and anti-hegemonism, with a focus on regional environment; and the adoption of non-military policies in addition to traditional military defense to preserve and promote national interests.¹³⁵ Structural realism has a lot to say about the changes that are taking place that invariably will affect Chinese security perception and policy; however, recent research has indicated that states facing similar external opportunities and constraints may not react in identical ways. In other words, there is more to the eye of the beholder. The introduction of strategic culture in the analysis helps to clarify some of the puzzle that structural realism has not been able to resolve.¹³⁶

¹³⁵ Weixing Hu, "China's security agenda after the cold war," *The Pacific Review* 8:1 (1995), pp.117-135.

¹³⁶ Alastair Iain Johnston, "Thinking about Strategic Culture," *International Security* 19, no.4 (Spring 1995), pp.32-64. A recent collective effort along this line can be

Strategic culture has been defined as “the set of attitudes and beliefs held within a military establishment concerning the political objective of war and the most effective strategy and operational method of achieving it.”¹³⁷ In a broader sense, it embodies “ranked grand strategic preferences derived from central paradigmatic assumptions about the nature of conflict and the enemy, and collectively shared by decision makers.”¹³⁸ Hence strategic culture as a “system of symbols” normally consists of the following elements: the basic assumptions about the nature of strategic environment (threat perception), about the nature of potential and actual adversaries, and about the efficacy of the use of violence/force in resolving inter-state conflicts.

Chinese strategic culture has a long history and revealed two major thrusts: the Confucian-Mencian non-violent, defensive, and accommodationist approach with an emphasis on stratagems over brute force,¹³⁹ and the *parabellum*, realpolitik understanding of the nature of conflicts, adversaries, and the use of force.¹⁴⁰ The latter perspective regards conflicts as a constant phenomenon of human life and interstate conflicts as zero-sum in nature. Peaceful environments are but a temporal hiatus during which time potential adversaries are planning for future attacks. This sense of insecurity is captured in the Chinese idiom: *ju'an siwei; youbei wuhuan* [think about

found in Peter J. Katzenstein, ed., *The Culture of National Security: Norms and Identity in World Politics* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1996), which explores alternatives to the predominant analytical perspectives of neorealism and neoliberalism in security studies.

¹³⁷ Yitzhak Klein, “A Theory of Strategic Culture,” *Comparative Strategy* 10:2 (January-March 1991), p.5.

¹³⁸ Alastair Iain Johnston, *Cultural Realism: Strategic Culture and Grand Strategy in Chinese History* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1995), p.ix.

¹³⁹ John K. Fairbank, “Introduction: Varieties of the Chinese Military Experience,” in Frank A. Kierman, Jr. and John K. Fairbank, eds., *Chinese Ways in Warfare* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1974), pp.1-26.

¹⁴⁰ Johnston, *Cultural Realism*, p.x.

dangers while residing in peace; sound preparation enables one to withstand calamity]. The use of force is not a choice but rather an imperative for the advancement of state interests and indeed, sometimes states survival. The best way to ensuring security is through the elimination of the sources of insecurity which, in most cases, are potential as well as actual adversaries. Since the use of force is inevitable, its offensive uses rather than defensive application becomes paramount. If history is any guide, when the country is unified and strong, then the Confucian-Mencian side of Chinese strategic culture seems to manifest itself in strategic thinking and policy choices. Otherwise, the *realpolitik*, *parabellum* views are more likely to prevail among the elite. However, as the discussion to this point should make clear, the relationship between strategic culture and Chinese security policy is at best co-relational rather than causal.

The emphasis on internal cohesion and regime stability therefore is historically conditioned and has consistently occupied the thinking of Chinese rulers, dynastic and communist alike. Internal security in terms of political (regime) stability and national unity, as compared to the traditional concern with physical survival, may increasingly become the core value of China's comprehensive security scheme. In this regard, Beijing is well aware of the fragility on this front, given rampant corruption and internal decay; political liberalism that erodes the legitimacy of the current regime; rising regionalism; ethnic unrest and separatist movements; massive migration and discontent of urban unemployed and underemployed; and those elements aimed at toppling the CCP rule. Coupled with these destabilizing elements are foreign interference and attempts at "peaceful evolution."¹⁴¹

¹⁴¹ Shambaugh, "Growing Strong," p.48.

This reveals the rationale behind Beijing's reevaluation of the sources of threat to Chinese security. As one analyst notes, "China's threat environment is strongly influenced by idiosyncratic factors, including the lessons of Chinese history, the belief that internal and external threats are closely related, and the lack of distinction between national security and regime security."¹⁴²

Goal Determination: International & Domestic Variables

Recent debates in international relations theory raise questions about the extent to which state action is either influenced by structural opportunities/constraints (anarchy and distribution of power) or by process and institutions. In other words, will world politics always be zero-sum, competitive given the absence of a central authority or state behaviors will respond both to the "objective" realities and norms and institutions, for example, regimes? To some, there is no unqualified causal link between anarchy and power politics; state policies can range from competition to cooperation.¹⁴³ An important question then remains whether China's security policy is both reactive to, and constrained, by the international systemic factors, and to what extent. Given that the "black box" remains a major obstacle in the analysis of internal policymaking processes, the more observable, and more "objective" variables such as capabilities and the international structure of power could offer a useful starting point.¹⁴⁴

¹⁴² Denny Roy, "China's Threat Environment," *Security Dialogue* 27:4 (1996), p.437.

¹⁴³ Alexander Wendt, "Anarchy is what states make of it: the social construction of power politics," *International Organization* 46:2 (Spring 1992), pp.391-425; Wendt, "The agent-structure problem in international relations theory," *International Organization* 41:3 (Summer 1987), pp.335-370.

¹⁴⁴ Michael Ng-Quinn, "International Systemic Constraints on Chinese Foreign Policy," in Samuel S. Kim, ed., *China and the World: Chinese Foreign Policy in the Post-Mao Era* (Boulder and London: Westview Press, 1984), pp.82-110.

To the extent that China will react to systemic constraints, the current situation where the new world order simply confers the US's unipolar moment and not multipolarity as China had anticipated, exerts pressure on China to break this state of affairs. China will first of all seek to balance US influence and power, although this need not be through formal alliance. By improving relations with other major powers and echoing and voicing certain common concerns, Beijing can expect to elicit sympathy if not outright objection to US predominance. China will also strive to close the gap, and this may be helped by its phenomenal growth rate in the past two decades. In any event, China will try to imitate and become a great power, as history teaches her that might counts. Great powers are admired and imitated.¹⁴⁵ In this regard, China's ultimate goal may be rather limited: it wants to be treated and respected as a great power even though it may not want to fulfill the responsibility that comes with being one.

Although China itself has avowedly denied it, seeking balance of power has figured quite prominently in China's post-1949 security policy formulation. By leaning toward one of the superpowers, Beijing has sought to redress its own disadvantaged position in the international system. It has served its purposes well. The question is: with the end of the Cold War and one remaining superpower, will the old game of strategic triangle continue to be a choice?¹⁴⁶

While it raises no particular controversy in asserting that

¹⁴⁵ For an argument why unipolarity cannot last long, see Christopher Layne, "The Unipolar Illusion: Why New Great Powers Will Rise," in Michael E. Brown, Sean M. Lynn-Jones, and Steven E. Miller, eds., *The Perils of Anarchy: Contemporary Realism and International Security* (Cambridge, Mass.: The MIT Press, 1995), pp.130-176. The article originally appeared in *International Security* 17:4 (Spring 1993).

¹⁴⁶ William T. Tow, "China and the International Strategic System," in Thomas W. Robinson and David Shambaugh, eds., *Chinese Foreign Policy: Theory and Practice* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1994), pp.115-157.

China will become a major power in the coming decade in both economic and military terms, it is less clear if and how the newly acquired capabilities will be applied to advance China's national security interests. What is lacking and requires further analysis are domestic variables in terms of what Shambaugh identifies as domestic politics, the decision-making milieu, and the elite's worldview.¹⁴⁷ Robert Jervis refers to subjective security demands.

Decision-makers act in terms of the vulnerability they feel, which can differ from the actual situation; we must therefore examine the decision-makers' subjective security requirements. Two dimensions are involved. First, even if they agree about the objective situation, people can differ about how much security they desire. ... The second aspect of subjective security is the perception of threat (that is, the estimate of whether the other will cooperate).¹⁴⁸

It is important to note that states are not unitary actors responding to external pressures. There are always competing internal interests/groups seeking to shape policy outcomes. They compete, bargain, and compromise, and policy outcomes represent these dynamics.¹⁴⁹ Domestic factors are increasingly recognized as important contributors to security policy making. This may be interpreted in two ways. One is that structural aspects in terms of opportunities and

¹⁴⁷ Shambaugh, "Containment or Engagement?"

¹⁴⁸ Jervis, "Cooperation under the Security Dilemma," pp.174-175.

¹⁴⁹ Samuel S. G. Wu and Bruce Bueno de Mesquita, "Assessing the Dispute in the South China Sea: A Model of China's Security Decision Making," *International Studies Quarterly* 38:3 (September 1994), pp.379-403.

constraints are as much subjective reconstruction as they are objective realities. In other words, external factors matter only when they are perceived so, although mistaken perceptions can cause states a great deal, as demonstrated by the Qing Dynasty. The other is that processes also matter. The issue of "securitization" is very important.

One recent review of the state of the study of Chinese foreign policy summarizes five general approaches: prior to the reform and opening up, three dominated the field: the *traditional/historical*, the *Maoist/communist ideological*, and the *realist/rational actor*; the last two decades have seen the development of an additional two: the institutional and the perceptual. The difference being one from treating China as a unitary actor to one that recognizes the complexity of factional/bureaucratic politics and institutional interests, and the images and perceptions held by Chinese policymakers, specialists, and scholars. Due to their divergent backgrounds, there tend to be diversity in perceptions, which in turn influence and inform policy deliberation and adoptions.¹⁵⁰

In the post-charismatic-leader era, institutional and perceptual approaches are becoming more important. With the passage of dominant leaders, debates on security policy involve more groups and institutional interests, in addition to competing perceptions of what are at stake.¹⁵¹ Also important, although still not clearly spelled out, is the growing role of China's expanding national security research bureaucracy.¹⁵²

¹⁵⁰ Bin Yu, "The Study of Chinese Foreign Policy: Problems and Prospect," *World Politics* 46:2 (January 1994), pp.235-261.

¹⁵¹ Ellis Joffe, *The Military and China's New Politics: Trends and Counter-Trends*, CAPS Papers No.19 (Taipei: Chinese Council of Advanced Policy Studies, September 1997).

¹⁵² For an overview of the developments up to the mid-1980s, see David L. Shambaugh, "China's National Security Research Bureaucracy," *The China Quarterly* 110 (June 1987), pp.276-304. Recent discussion includes Michael D. Swaine, "The PLA in China's National Security Policy: Leaderships, Structure, Processes," *The*

An understanding of the structure and process of China's NSRB can help better-informed analysis of the country's security policy in at least two dimensions. One is a better grasp of the historical/cultural genesis of China's security policy. The writings of, certainly also is true of the policy advice from, China's NSRB can reveal the extent to which the holistic approach to national security remains the core of strategic thinking since ancient times. A related issue would be that greater exchanges with members of China's NSRB should enable a better understanding of the cultural premises of Chinese thinking of security issues and security policy and hence help to avoid the tendency of "mirror image" of ethnocentrism.¹⁵³ The other is more relevant to Western analysts and policymakers alike, in that the greater exposure to concepts such as common security, cooperative security, multilateralism, reassurance as opposed to deterrence can bring about perceptual change in understanding the sources of threats and means to achieve security. In other words, if the epistemic community argument is valid, are we going to see some "learning" in the offing or adaptation only?¹⁵⁴

National vs. International Security Policy

If the demise of the Soviet Union provides any lesson, it is that national security is based on comprehensive national strength, which includes a strong and dynamic economic and technological base, national unity and cohesion, and political stability, in addition to a modern military force.¹⁵⁵ National security can be achieved through adroit diplomatic maneuver.

China Quarterly 146 (June 1996), pp.360-393.

¹⁵³ Booth, *Strategy and Ethnocentrism*.

¹⁵⁴ Special issue on epistemic communities, *International Organization* 46:1 (Winter 1992); Johnston, "Learning versus Adaptation."

¹⁵⁵ Shambaugh, "Growing Strong," p.45.

China's skillful application of various stratagems over the past five decades, ranging from alliance with the Soviet Union, to tight alignment with the United States, to tilted equidistance, or the so-called independent foreign policy,¹⁵⁶ is testimony to the traditional Chinese strategic culture, i.e., *famou* [diplomatic manoeuvre] is to complement, and indeed may be preferable to, *fabing* [resort to use of force].

This probably explains that while at the perceptual level, Mao's strategic thinking was clearly steeped in the *parabellum* paradigm, at the operational level, it demonstrated sufficient flexibility. There was no clear *a priori* order of ranked strategies and certainly no rigid preference of offensive over defensive strategies. Indeed, the offense-defense dichotomy was treated more in a dialectic sense in that the two sets of strategy complement or reinforce rather than exclude and separate each other. Indeed, sometimes defense as a tactic is a necessary prelude to offense and a protracted struggle can be expected before a final victory.¹⁵⁷ It is a matter of timing as much as it is of choice. Here Mao was acutely sensitive to shifts of relative capabilities. Consequently, "[t]he more this balance [of relative capabilities] is favorable, the more advantageous it is to adopted [sic] offensive coercive strategies; the less favorable, the more advantageous it is to adopted [sic] defensive or accommodationist strategies to buy time until the balance shifts again."¹⁵⁸ And such shifts toward one's advantage seldom present themselves but must be worked upon. Consequently the state's heavy industries and atomic weapons are built.¹⁵⁹

¹⁵⁶ David Shambaugh, "China's Security Policy in the Post-Cold War Era," *Survival* 34:2 (Summer 1992), pp.88-106.

¹⁵⁷ Scott A. Boorman, *The Protracted Game: A Wei-Ch'i Interpretation of Maoist Revolutionary Strategy* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1969).

¹⁵⁸ Johnston, "Cultural Realism and Strategy in Maoist China," pp.219-220.

¹⁵⁹ John Wilson Lewis and Xue Litai, *China Builds the Bomb* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1988).

Two considerations affect the use of force in managing China's security *problematique*. On the one hand, growing interdependence in inter-state relations both opens up more avenues for resolving disputes/conflicts and by extension, renders the use of force to only one, and not even the preferred one among many options. Increasingly, policy makers have to consider any fallout from the use of force that may affect the likelihood of achieving other objectives. In other words, issues can no longer be demarcated and separated. On the other hand, Desert Storm clearly demonstrates the efficacy of the use of force (the lesson: diplomacy alone is hardly sufficient in resolving territorial disputes) and in particular the importance of initiatives which, in military parlance, mean the offensive use of force.

Most analysts also recognize that China's capabilities even for obtaining its limited security goals (Taiwan, territorial claims) are quite limited and it may take a long while before this situation is redressed.¹⁶⁰ Power projection for China remains beyond grasp and aspiration on the drawing board. Despite recent efforts to enhance such capabilities, there remain severe obstacles in finance, organization, and ability to absorb and integrate technology, and so on. "Pockets of excellence" may remain the feature in years to come.¹⁶¹

The realist underpinning of Chinese security policy dictates that it will be less inclined to adopt cooperative approaches for fear that others may gain and/or cheat. Robert Jervis's observation is pertinent in understanding China's behavior, or why China has not adopted certain policy orientation in areas

¹⁶⁰ Chong-Pin Lin, "The Military Balance in the Taiwan Straits," *The China Quarterly* 146 (June 1996), pp.577-595.

¹⁶¹ See, for example, Paul Dibb, "The Future Military Capabilities of Asia's Great Powers," *Jane's Intelligence Review* 7:5 (July 1995), pp.229-233; Bates Gill and Taeho Kim, *China's Arms Acquisitions from Abroad: A Quest for 'Superb and Secret Weapons'* SIPRI Research Report No. 11 (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1995).

such as arms control.¹⁶² "States that can afford to be cheated in a bargain or that cannot be destroyed by a surprise attack can more easily trust others and need not act at the first, and ambiguous, sign of menace."¹⁶³ China obviously cannot afford such "luxury." On the contrary, China may feel insecure and threatened in a unipolar world. To address such an imbalance of power, China must either seek balance through alliance, or try to enhance its own capabilities to defend itself. Given that Beijing has long eschewed the first choice and avowed not to be engaged in any similar venture in the future, then the second choice, building a powerful country and strong army has become the natural choice. As Christopher Layne observes, "in a unipolar system, the structural pressures on potential great powers (like China) to increase their relative capabilities and become great powers should be overwhelming."¹⁶⁴

In a similar vein, one may suggest that institutions may only constrain China's behavior not so much of the institutions themselves, which, according to realists, are a reflection of distribution of power, but the calculations of benefit and cost of whether or not to comply with the relevant rules and norms.¹⁶⁵ This is particularly the case with the existing multilateral non-proliferation regimes, which seek to control the spread of weapons of mass destruction or conventional weapons and technology.

¹⁶² J. Mohan Malik, "China's Policy Toward Nuclear Arms Control in the Post-Cold War Era," *Contemporary Security Policy* 16:2 (August 1995), pp.1-43; Mitchel B. Wallerstein, "China and Proliferation: A Path Not Taken?" *Survival* 38:3 (Autumn 1996), pp.58-66; Banning N. Garrett and Bonnie S. Glaser, "Chinese Perspectives on Nuclear Arms Control," *International Security* 20:3 (Winter 1995/96), pp.43-78

¹⁶³ Jervis, "Cooperation under the Security Dilemma," p.172.

¹⁶⁴ Layne, "A House of Cards: American Strategy toward China," *World Policy Journal* XIV:3 (Fall 1997), p.81.

¹⁶⁵ John J. Mearsheimer, "The False Promise of International Institutions," *International Security* 19:3 (Winter 1994/95).

Chinese perspective on and approach to multilateralism would also be a helpful indicator of its willingness to adopt cooperative security measures. To suggest that China is less than forthcoming toward multilateral approach to regional security issues, as most analyses do, only raises one of several important questions concerning the broader debates about international cooperation and the behaviors of rising/aspiring powers. The more appropriate questions may be if, and how, China is different from other major powers with regard to multilateralism; what are the conditions for the creation of security regimes; how China's history, strategic culture, and domestic politics affect its perspectives on multilateralism; how and to what extent past experiences in multilateral settings influence and shape China's attitudes and behaviors; and finally, if there are more than one "script," or version of Chinese multilateralism.

International relations scholars have long debated the range of options states can adopt in conducting their relations and the possibility of international cooperation under anarchy. Realists are normally pessimistic and argue that relative-gain considerations make international cooperation elusive, if not altogether impossible. Liberal institutionalists, on the other hand, point out that international cooperation is not only possible but also highly desirable because it reduces transaction costs and makes interstate relations more predictable.¹⁶⁶

The realist understanding of international relations would suggest that international cooperation would be difficult but possible to some degree under certain circumstances.¹⁶⁷ In

¹⁶⁶ Robert O. Keohane, ed., *Neorealism and Its Critics* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1986); David A. Baldwin, ed., *Neorealism and Neoliberalism: The Contemporary Debate* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1993).

¹⁶⁷ Charles L. Glaser, "Realists as Optimists: Cooperation as Self-Help," in Brown, Lynn-Jones, and Miller, *The Perils of Anarchy*, pp.377-417.

this regard, realism would explain states' willingness to behave cooperatively and their participation in multilateral arrangements, be they international organizations and acceptance of certain norms and principles concerning behavior, as largely utility-oriented. In other words, states choose cooperation out of rational choice. Two points immediately come to mind: One, that states, and in particular great powers, may be less than forthcoming if they see multilateral arrangements as potentially constraining; and two, they may be prepared to endorse multilateral arrangements if the latter do not impose significant constraints or if nonparticipation per se accrue non absolute gains but relative losses (in terms of opportunities created through collective actions or simply the tarnishing of image).

The above discussion indicates that whether a state is more receptive to multilateralism or more cooperative in security issues can be highly situation-specific and may never be consistent. Brian Job has identified what he calls as "deep" multilateralist arrangements with relatively narrow and exclusionary membership, and "shallower" forms of multilateralist commitments with broader and more inclusive membership. There is always a tension, or trade-off between the two; more so in the context of regional perspectives and practices. Regional powers tend to eschew multilateral arrangements that may entail domination or restrictions imposed on them by major powers. They are also likely to avoid such multilateral forums that may constrain their autonomy and freedom of action.¹⁶⁸

China has responded to international regimes in arms control and non-proliferation differently and over time. If one

¹⁶⁸ Brian L. Job, "Matters of Multilateralism: Implications for Regional Conflict Management," in David A. Lake and Patrick M. Morgan, eds., *Regional Orders: Building Security in a New World* (University Park, PA: The Pennsylvania State University Press, 1997), pp.165-191.

suggests that institutions reflect distribution of power, and one also realizes that China was absent in the making of all these regimes, then one must explain why over time China has come to embrace some of them, and from an outsider to an insider. Change of structural features? Perceptions of the cost and benefits of embracing? Tactical adaptation? One thing that has transpired is that China so far has not sought to change the rules of these regimes as conditions of joining and once in, has shown more of a status quo power than a revisionist (e.g., NPT). Clearly, systemic level analysis alone cannot fully account for change and the selectiveness of policy.

This raises the question of learning and how it helps our understanding of the changes in Chinese security policy over time.¹⁶⁹ This refers to two concepts: learning in the sense that growing experience in various multilateral forums will make the Chinese both aware of the many benefits resultant from active participation and better multilateralist; and learning to the extent there is a fundamental change in their perceptions of the nature of threat and the appreciation that there are alternative, and hopefully more cost-effective ways of dealing with security dilemmas other than the traditional, realist self-help approaches. While one may suggest that learning has certainly occurred in the first instance, that in the second, namely, the recognition of security interdependence and the relevant policy changes, has yet to take place.

V. Conclusion

This essay has sought to ground the study of Chinese security policy in a more systematic, theoretically informed framework. I suggested that most analyses of post-Cold War

¹⁶⁹ See Jack S. Levy, "Learning and Foreign Policy: Sweeping a Conceptual Minefield," *International Organization* 48:2 (Spring 1994), pp.279-312.

Chinese security policy tend to be policy-contingent, ad hoc, and lack historical and comparative perspective. This explains why discussions range from the alarmist to the over-confident. The absence of a more rigorous analytical framework is due to a large extent to the artificial separation of security studies and area/country (in our case, Sinology) studies.

The brief review of the recent debates in security studies was intended to highlight a number of key issues and provide some useful synthesized groundwork upon which new approaches to the study of Chinese security policy can be developed. An analytical framework that takes equal measures of structure, process, players, and their interactions at both the international and domestic levels, and informed in both historical and comparative perspectives may improve the chance of producing more balanced account of Chinese security policy and its implications for international and regional peace and stability. I also believe that the framework can be further improved through the incorporation of some of the insights found in comparative foreign policy literature.

In this regard, important research remains to be undertaken in relation to the following issues: What informs and shapes the current Chinese leadership's view of interstate relations (interdependent or zero-sum conflictual)?¹⁷⁰ What is the role of the military in national security decisionmaking?¹⁷¹ Does the traditional *wen-wu* (and today's Party-Army) relationship still hold?¹⁷² And how do developments in these areas affect

¹⁷⁰ Michael D. Swaine, *China: Domestic Change and Foreign Policy* (Santa Monica, Calif.: RAND, 1995); David Shambaugh, "Containment or Engagement of China? Calculating Beijing's Responses," *International Security* 21, no.2 (Fall 1996), pp.180-209.

¹⁷¹ Michael D. Swaine, *The Role of the Chinese Military in National Security Policymaking* (Santa Monica, Calif.: RAND, 1996).

¹⁷² Michael D. Swaine, *The Military and Political Succession in China* (Santa Monica, Calif.: RAND, 1992); Nan Li, "Political-Military Changes in China, 1978-89,"

the implementation as well as the contents of Chinese security policy and, by extension affect the contours of Asia-Pacific security?

Security Studies 4, no.2 (Winter 1994/95), pp.426-458.